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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RfScME8c_4k
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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[00:01:04] I'm actually going to introduce all three speakers right now, just because that'll allow us to have a seamless set of discussions.

[00:01:37] And at the end of the presentations, we'll have an opportunity as a board to raise questions. So if you'll make note as we're moving through, I think that would be most helpful. As I indicated at the beginning, we're actually going to be starting with John Watson, who's going to be sharing national perspective on the landscape of virtual learning.

[00:01:55] he is with the digital learning collaborative he was founder of the evergreen educational group which has been a research and advisory firm in k-12 online learning for more than 22 years and we're super delighted to have him here today informing this conversation following John Watson we're going to hear from dr. Brian Mott who is actually here in the room as the executive director of Virtual Virginia.

[00:02:22] Dr. Mott joined Virtual Virginia in 2007 as an instructor prior to moving into program administration. And his presentation is going to focus on providing us with a comprehensive overview of Virtual Virginia, including a history of how it's grown, student achievement outcomes, instructional practices, and professional development support that's provided to teachers.

[00:02:47] And following Dr. Mott, we're going to hear from cindy hamblin of the virtual learning leadership alliance where she serves as director she's going to be speaking to the state digital learning programs that exist across the country and again we're just delighted to have all of these individuals with us today as we dig into this topic to learn a little bit more about virtual learning so i'm going to start and invite john to uh kick us off with this first uh presentation thank you so much for being here

[00:03:21] hello and thank you for the opportunity to address the board i i believe that this topic is incredibly important i appreciate the work that you're doing uh this this type of work i do believe is able to expand opportunities for students and improve educational outcomes so i'm grateful for the opportunity to uh to present today as was mentioned in the introduction i found and run the Evergreen Education Group.

[00:03:47] We're a boutique organization. We've been involved in K-12 digital learning in many forms for 22 years. My partners and I have been invited to testify to state legislatures, charter school commissions. We've guided state agencies, individual schools and districts in their own planning and development of their online and hybrid schools and programs.

[00:04:07] We also run the Digital Learning Annual Conference, which this past year drew more than 1,500 people Atlanta and online and we run the digital learning collaborative the membership group I mentioned all that because I just want to frame that my comments aren't so much just reflecting my views as much as they're reflecting the views that we hear from our thousands of attendees and members and folks like that I am convinced that based on working in this field for more than two decades the digital learning in all its forms can create more opportunities and better outcomes for students. I've seen these positive outcomes in different

[00:04:46] states and schools that we've worked with and the research that we've done and through my own extended family. I also want to be clear though that we don't believe for a second that digital learning is a silver bullet. Digital learning in all its forms it needs to be well planned, well implemented to be successful. It's organizations like Virtual Virginia as well as the work of individual school divisions and school leaders that are clearly critical to the success of all forms of digital learning. Speaking of those forms, I want to point out that online learning,

[00:05:21] it can be supplemental or it can be full-time. It can be offered at different levels by the division, by the state, or even at a national level. It might be courses accessed from home, accessed from school, or from other locations. It might be offered primarily using real-time video or resources accessed by students at their own pace, or most likely a combination of both.

[00:05:43] So digital learning, broadly speaking, has nearly limitless permutations. But I want to just to drill down a bit, categorize digital learning into three main forms. And I'm thinking about across the U.S. First, there's the full-time online schools that are the students' main or only source of education the second one is the supplemental online courses that are taken by students who are enrolled elsewhere in a physical school typically often they're in rural areas in which that online course may be the only option for advanced math science or world languages

[00:06:22] instruction these are the types of courses that we know prepare students to be a successful part of a 21st century workforce third category broadly speaking are the hybrid schools that combine online and face-to-face instruction in ways that take the best of both modalities to expand learning beyond the usual barriers of time and place and these engage students as well by allowing them a greater level of

agency a greater level of control over both their own education and what they're doing with the rest of their time whether in a pursuit or an internship or a job or something

[00:06:58] else i also want to point out that digital learning that took place pre-pandemic is very different from the emergency remote learning that occurred during the pandemic although the efforts of teachers and school leaders during the pandemic were often heroic that conflation of emergency remote learning with the pre-pandemic digital learning i think it's given digital learning a bad name emergency remote learning was implemented of necessity with very little planning it was intended to be temporary and because of that short time frame support for teachers in most

[00:07:35] cases was very limited. None of these negative aspects are true with the types of online and hybrid learning that existed pre-pandemic are and are now re-emerging or they existed throughout the pandemic but they're really becoming more important than ever. One thing in particular during emergency remote learning a lot of instruction was heavily dependent on real-time video. In contrast what we see among the more experienced online and hybrid schools and programs is that they often combine teacher support and student-directed learning as students move through

[00:08:11] materials in a way that's partly guided by a teacher and might include some real-time video but it's also very significantly student-directed as well and and based on asynchronous interaction where students are working with materials and working with teachers through email discussion boards and a variety of different communication modes so that sets up the landscape i just want to talk for a few more minutes about a few ways to frame the digital learning discussion. First thing is that it's very clear that teachers are as important in digital learning as they are in

[00:08:48] mainstream forms of education as well. As I mentioned earlier, we've been studying this field for more than 20 years and we have found that literally 100% of successful online and hybrid schools and programs use teachers in central roles for delivering instruction and supporting students.

[00:09:04] this means that teacher recruitment preparation evaluation and ongoing support is absolutely critical it also highlights the role and the value of virtual virginian and not only how it supports its own teachers but how it can play an ongoing role with teachers across the common tied to this fact that teachers are so critical is that innovative schools and programs are thinking about how to best use teachers and other caring professional adults in a variety of roles some schools are elevating the roles of counselors and other mentors in ways that alleviate some of the

[00:09:41] workload on teachers. Other schools are adding these counseling and mentoring roles to teachers workloads. Because of these varying approaches to how schools are using teachers and other professionals, I've been very cautious about setting either requirements or expectations around issues like student-teacher ratio. Because in the digital world, these can be successfully higher or lower than in traditional schools. Second, I want to make the point that we should keep in mind that providing digital learning options is truly about offering options for students. As a Commonwealth, you're not

[00:10:20] making a decision about online and hybrid versus in-person. Ideally, in my opinion, you're creating options for all students and all families that they can choose from. Creating more online and hybrid options for some students doesn't hold back any other students in any way.

[00:10:38] Contrary to that, I've actually seen the students over two plus decades who are really well served by a new type of environment. So often they're engaged because they find their interests, whether

in a career, a pursuit, or college, in a learning environment, a different learning environment that supports their interests fully.

[00:11:01] Third, I also want to be clear that it's really important to recognize in your discussions that online and hybrid learning mean something very different for let's say a second grade student versus a high school senior. Age differences are predictive of the varied reasons why students and families choose online options, and also good online instructional strategies and methods are very different for students of different ages.

[00:11:26] So in your deliberations, I would encourage you to think about whether you're considering all ages and to what extent requirements or recommendations are different for those different ages. Lastly, I believe that we're in the late stages of this pandemic and emerging from what was emergency remote learning and as such, and because so many students, teachers, families across the Commonwealth and across the country experience some sort of digital learning during the phase of emergency remote learning, that means we're now at an inflection point for digital learning and for education as a whole.

[00:12:03] I believe the best path forward involves looking to the experienced online educators in programs like Virtual Virginia, while welcoming increased involvement from school divisions across the Commonwealth. I thank you for the opportunity to testify before the board today.

[00:12:20] Best wishes for your important work and again thanks for having me. Thank you so much. Are you going to be able to stay on as we listen to the other presenters so that there can be an opportunity at the end for questions? I will stay on, yes.

[00:12:35] Wonderful. Thank you. we'll move on to our next presenter I think Dr. Mott is here in the room yes thank you so much for being here thank you good afternoon and it's a uh it's a pleasure to be here today um you know Virtual Virginia is a large program and a lot has happened over the last several years I'm going to catch up on some of that and talk about where we're going in the future as well uh honor to be here today especially today as the Virtual Virginia community joins the board Superintendent at Baylow and the department in honoring our military families and military children.

[00:13:14] Not only today, not only this month, but always at Virtual Virginia, we honor our military families. There's a longstanding policy where we reserve space in all of our courses for military transfers throughout the year. We often know a military life is often a mobile life, and so we want to be as accommodating as possible to all of our families.

[00:13:32] And we have many families that enroll in Virtual Virginia specifically for that flexibility from the beginning of the year. They know they may be moving. so we have a long history of supporting military families at Virtual Virginia, and it's a small measure we can do to show our support today. So let's start at the top. I talked about where we're going to define Virtual Virginia, where we've been and where we are going. Virtual Virginia is the Virginia Department of Ed's K-12 online instruction, summer learning, statewide LMS and digital content, and professional learning provider. We provide opportunities for students and educators across the Commonwealth. Virginia Public Schools and Virtual Virginia partner together, so that's how

[00:14:11] this works it's a partnership and we work together to ensure that learners have access and opportunity that complement those available in the physical school we have four programs of virtual Virginia as I referenced the k-12 instruction program our outreach program which is the statewide

learning management system and our professional learning and summer learning programs and today I'm going to go over all four of these programs and give you a little bit of a history and where we are going forward let's begin with our k-12 instruction program at virtual Virginia one of the most updated stats we want to

[00:14:44] share today is our participation in this school year in our K-12 program. Nearly all divisions in the Commonwealth currently participate in Virtual Virginia, 97% of divisions this year. And I referenced that partnership and how it works. This has been our long-standing model at Virtual Virginia. We're trying to create the environment for successful online learners. And in our K-12 program, Virtual Virginia provides access to the instruction, content, resources, and that teacher of record in that learning environment. The enrolling school also has shared responsibility.

[00:15:21] They provide all the student services, a local school counselor, a mentor role, and any textbooks, materials, and resources needed for that student to be successful online. And working together, we have a long and rich history of successful online learners in the Commonwealth. One piece that we didn't include there was parent accounts as well. Parent and guardians are welcomed into virtual virginia they are champions in student learning online and so we want to partner with them as well and make sure that they have access to the student access to all the information the school has and access to the same information and data the teacher has in that online course as well

[00:15:57] students who are enrolled in virtual virginia do remain affiliated with their school division's adm so they remain attached to that local community that local school and remain part of that local culture and again those accounts again create transparency right with the school division and in this relationship, transparency breeds trust. People trust Virtual Virginia because they can see student success, they can see teacher interaction, and they can see how that works to support learners. And again, providing access to data for all of those roles is critical, real actionable

[00:16:30] data where learners can perform, stakeholders can support, and we can move on data very quickly in our system. Now, Virtual Virginia, we get the question all the time, are we a pandemic-related program? No. Virtual Virginia's been around for almost 40 years. Virtual Virginia was established as the Virginia Satellite Education Network in 1984. And back then we had satellites that would broadcast live instruction all over the Commonwealth. There were telephones and hotlines and teachers could phone students. And it was successful for a long period of time. And later

[00:17:05] the Virtual Virginia AP school, which was online, was added to the program. Obviously the duplicating of efforts there. Both programs were combined in 2006 to create Virtual Virginia. And in the early years, it was mostly in-person learners who were taking courses supplementally, right, using that satellite network. Well, once the programs combined, it was imperative that it became a complement to local school offerings. It was a priority on providing opportunity and moving from that fixed to flexible modality, moving from students sitting in a classroom receiving their instruction

[00:17:42] to students receiving instruction, but being able to access their classroom. As the program grew and expanded, a full-time program was launched in 2015, where students could enroll and take all of their courses to complete the graduation requirements at Virtual Virginia. Shortly after, a K-5 program was entertained and created in 2020.

[00:18:04] Virtual Virginia has grown over the years, and I'll share some of that growth with you here in just a moment, but particularly as we move from part-time to including those full-time authoring. Now,

there were some challenges along the way, and a lot of that related to our data and how the program reported. And essentially, long ago, it was decided that it would not be tied to the state longitudinal data system. There'd be a separate rostering and registration system.

[00:18:29] So largely, data was self-reported. I've been here since 2006, and I can remember phoning schools and saying, hey, how did this student do on this assessment? Obviously, as we grew into a larger program that was no longer sustainable. So we're very happy to report that this year, Virtual Virginia now reports via Master Scheduling and MSC report, and that data will be validated 100% and cross-checked. So very excited to see that move forward. And we know that's a challenge with other statewide programs, is getting the data 100% accurate. We're excited to lead on that here in Virginia. When I included some of those old logos there, we were also happy to move on from those

[00:19:05] over time as well. So what does K-12 instruction look like at Virtual Virginia? As John reference before me uh it can two modalities asynchronous and synchronous and all of our content our asynchronous content is developed and reviewed by virginia public educators that's critical it's created for virginia public educators by virginia public education we do offer daily synchronous as well and we know that that model is unique so our synchronous consists of whole group instruction one-to-one and small group instruction and also additional opportunities for remediation

[00:19:44] enrichment teachers do have office hours for student and parent and guardian engagement all throughout the day that's critical we know that and in grades k through five students are taught core subjects including specials computer science art dance history pe stem and world languages and in grades 6 through 12 students can create a personalized schedule from up to 120 courses so why do students engage in virtual virginia well we thankfully we do survey all of our students and parents and we glean some of that information and this is from the last two

[00:20:22] years we haven't issued the end of your survey yet this school year but it's coming but we can point to some data points here that are interesting the first is a growth and a preference for virtual courses another is growth in the course not being available locally so what we have is we have everybody you know learn new skills over the last couple of years and we have a more comfortable level with virtual learning and more digital learning and we also have people looking for options beyond what's available in the physical school so virtual virginia is uniquely positioned

[00:20:55] to support both of those needs and here's some of the enrollment data from the last three years you can see beginning in 2019 of the total students is in red part-time is in black and full-time is in yellow you can see rapid growth in full-time learners because the needs changed across the commonwealth this school year but there's always been traditional growth in all three programs going back even years before this data and of course we do offer non-public enrollments as well to the program again not a large group but showing growth as well particularly in our

[00:21:34] homeschool populations who are have more options available now and are exploring virtual virginia potentially to support their learners as well so let's dig down a bit into this year some really interesting enrollment information. In the fall is a top graphic. You can see in the gray, that's full-time K5. The yellow is full-time 6 through 12. The black is part-time enrollment in 6 through 12.

[00:21:59] And the red is total. Interestingly, K5, you may not be able to see based on where you're sitting, but K5 grew full-time during the year. That's non-traditional trending. Usually in an online program like

Virtual Virginia, students may start off and then realize they need to transition back to in-person, our K-5 program grew during the school year. Full-time 6 through 12 was anticipated.

[00:22:24] The number would drop off a little bit as students returned to in-person. However, what was unanticipated was the growth in part-time 6 through 12. That gives us a couple of different opportunities here. One is that students were looking for more options throughout the school year, part-time in supplemental modality, but also some of the students who were full-time at Virtual Virginia that transitioned back to in-person retained one or two courses. So they remain part-time virtual learners when they transition back to in-person. So all of this information helps us gather where we're going going forward. Here's some more of that survey

[00:23:00] information I shared with you earlier. We're really pleased with these results. 88% of students when they complete a Virtual Virginia course would feel comfortable taking another. 85% of parents and guardians would enroll their student in Virtual Virginia again. 92% of school personnel are completely or moderately satisfied with the virtual Virginia program.

[00:23:21] And one that's really important to me, 90% of school personnel believe that students' virtual Virginia experiences create a positive view of virtual learning. As I mentioned earlier, we are working to get our data 100% validated.

[00:23:38] Some of our partners, including the College Board, has done some of that advanced work for us, and they recognized long ago that virtual programs supporting AP learners statewide didn't necessarily have that cross-check of data. so they create the ap classroom and through the ap classroom students with although they're enrolled in a local school division taking a course to an online provider are tied to that provider so for the last two years of the ap college board's classroom we have been able to glean reliable data on ap test performance here is 2020 of the exams we offered virtual virginia

[00:24:13] students scored higher on 61 percent higher based on a score of three to five that's typically regarded as the passing range although the college board may not like us saying that but that's how it's reported in schools we follow that same reporting structure and virtual virginia students on 65 percent of exams beat the global pass rate as well so we were really pleased with those until this year when it improved when virtual virginia students scored higher on 74 of exams both nationwide and compared to their peers in virginia so we're beginning to see some

[00:24:49] data coming that's reliable and we're really pleased with these up front with the ap scores and here's some examples of what that looks like as well you can see that you know these are just four of the examinations but ap comparative government ap computer science which we built with our partners at code va ap macro economics and ap spanish and language and culture you can see how virtual virginia students compare to their peers in both the commonwealth and nationwide so the backbone of our program is our instructors in our k-12 program virtual virginia we do use

[00:25:25] part-time and full-time k-12 educators they all possess a valid virginia teaching license and we do a pretty extensive recruitment process and i'll share with you where our teachers currently live in just a moment we recruit in the commonwealth and across the country we aren't bound by geography but like some school divisions may be they have to get teachers that are relatively close to their division we're able to recruit the best teachers from anywhere in the country and around the globe now we put a lot of emphasis on our recruitment process and all of our teachers must create a teaching with virtual virginia course before we

[00:26:00] even offer them a potential to work with us they also have to demonstrate and practice that they know how to teach online with us as well so our recruitment process is pretty strenuous for our teachers but um we feel that that's necessary because of the work that they are doing they are they must not be under contract with another virginia public school we don't play that game essentially we only offer teachers who are available and they do have to participate in regular professional development which i'll dig into in just a moment we did talk uh john had mentioned it briefly about teacher ratios and loads in the absence of current regulation we

[00:26:37] do follow the soq and soa at virtual virginia for our full-time educators and as i mentioned this uh this map changes we don't have time to really pretty it up because it always is moving as we add faculty and staff to the program but you can see uh where they live and largely it's east west north south in the commonwealth across the country and we also have a global representation as well in costa rica we have two on a base in germany they're military families and we also have one currently in spain so we are fortunate in that we are able to recruit and find the best qualified

[00:27:12] educators and we are very happy to uh to welcome more to our family because it is a growing family and they are so energized and they're such a great staff i've referenced earlier about some of our professional development and we are really proud of our educators and how they are highly trained highly qualified and and being the best in class essentially we offer internal opportunities such as at ed camp at the beginning of the school year that's a week-long training online for our teachers to get ready we offer weekly lunch and learn workshops every wednesday at 12 30. monthly

[00:27:50] professional learning activities that are aligned to the national standards for quality online teaching and we do uh plc special learning communities as well grade level subject area groups within our faculty we're also proud of our partnership with quality matters we have many of our educators complete the k-12 rubric the reviewer course and the accessibility and usability workshops provided through quality matters so really excited about continuing our endeavors with that group and other professional organizations such as john watson's digital

[00:28:23] Learning Leadership Alliance. You know, one thing to think about here is Virtual Virginia is a peer group of one in the Commonwealth. There aren't any statewide programs, there's one. And so it's important for us to reach out to other states to see how, see where we sit, learn from them, and some of that best professional development we can get as an organization is learning about how others in the country approach the same challenges that we do. So where are we going? Virtual Virginia, we are poised to grow quite a bit in the next school year. Our K-12 instructional program has grown dramatically over several years as we've shown, but we're poised to add growth in students

[00:29:03] enrolling both part-time in-person or full-time online learners. This year we've had that unique shift where some of our full-time learners transitioned back to in-person but remained enrolled in several virtual Virginia courses. So we see that the needs shifting and we want to make sure that we are flexible enough to meet those needs. We do see again that shift to support in-person learning needs as students go back into school buildings they've all learned new skills our world has changed and we want to make sure that we are supporting both students and educators in this new world we are finding more highly qualified virginia instructors to work at virtual virginia

[00:29:40] we're out recruiting now uh we are looking at more core and supplemental opportunities in k5 we are i'd like to sit here before you and say we've got this all figured out but we're still learning and so we

want to make sure our k5 program is aligned to the needs in k5 particularly as some of those learners in grades three through five who are looking for more asynchronous options.

[00:30:00] We still offer the daily synchronous but there are some learners who prefer that asynchronous route. We are adding more courses for learners in grades six through twelve and again increasing those synchronous opportunities, moving them around, not making them as fixed, making them more flexible for learners so they can engage with their teacher in small group or in whole group settings on a more regular basis. I'm going to shift gears and talk about another virtual Virginia program for just a moment this is our outreach program this program is where virtual virginia provides a statewide learning management system and k-12 course content for at no cost for virginia public

[00:30:38] schools our participation map for this one's a little easier 100 100 of school divisions have the lms it's a statewide learning management system they're at differing stages of adoptions at this point some are just exploring some have just turned it on in case they need it others are are in full-on adoption of the learning management system and let me explain what an instance is so we make the learning management system available for schools and give them full control over how they orchestrate it okay we don't mandate how it's developed we give them the learning management system 24 7 support training and content and they'll let them build it how they want to build

[00:31:15] it to support their learners as i mentioned we are at differing levels of adoption implementation in this program so we're constantly doing training constantly doing support for all of those differing needs across the state i could sit here and talk all day about why this program is critical um but you know i'll just go through a few points here this program was established in 2012 with one course it was the economics of personal finance course we built with the virginia council for economic education and we provide that lms and that content available but really there's reasons

[00:31:52] behind why it's important why a learning management system well at some point automation is key right everything has been automated at accelerated rate over the last two years and k-12 education is not immune to that as i mentioned earlier every part of our lives have changed and our k-12 system needs to reflect that but how do we support those students interoperability is critical going forward everybody's learned new tools how do those tools interact and how does that data interact in a secure space. So what I like in the LMS too is those big Lego plates when we were kids, those big

[00:32:27] green squares. Every tool that we use is a Lego. It fits and it talks and it communicates and it all links together. And LMS provides that space for school divisions. Organizing everything securely in one place. Again, keeping our data secure as more and more data comes into our systems. And LMS provides unlimited access for learners. They can access the class. They can access resources outside of the traditional school building or school day it does provide real-time actionable data and some of this at virtual virginia we've been using a learning management system since 2016. some of those uh actionable data points are are critical you know

[00:33:05] as students don't log in or they don't complete an assignment or the grades start to slip that data is real time you need to have that available and providing an lms is a way to really harness that data and track progress and performance there is cost savings clearly on things like printing travel professional learning you can put all that on a learning management system in your division and do things a bit more efficiently efficiently it does expand the division's profile so division can offer more options for their learners and their educators it is a it's a digital ecosystem

[00:33:40] which is really a 2022 solution to 2022 problems you know we can't keep throwing 2010 solutions at 22 problems we have to use real world tools to solve them i know these are buzzwords but blended learning and personalized education are more easily attainable using a digital system like a learning management system and again that transparency you know all of our parents and guardians that see our courses they can log in and see them at any time and that transparency for parents and guardians is critical we're at an all-time high engagement right now and we need to leverage that engagement to help our learners succeed so providing a digital space where learners

[00:34:16] can access their courses for does provide more transparency at home and some examples and we've seen schools all you know the last year spin up these solutions are you know snow days you can run them virtually uh you know you have a sub or if you have a new teacher you can bring in resources very quickly and support that educator so they can begin teaching i did reference we are we do create content as well and make it available on the learning management system what's available now in k5 are resources in reading writing math social studies science and

[00:34:52] stem in a grade 6 through 12 we have all the core content ap world language computer science health and pe and credit recovery content available as well all at no cost for school divisions to go in download modify use however they like we started tracking the downloads initially on that content uh two years ago we hit a hundred thousand and then it was just wide open the school divisions can download one course make changes to it and make copies locally and we don't even know so we got to 100 000 we figured that was a safe number to stop at that point and we are expanding

[00:35:27] we're creating more content next year additional core academic and elective content additional world language health pe we're adding cte fine and performing arts computer science english language supports and career exploration to the catalog next year all available to public school divisions all for free all downloaded with within a few seconds just getting click download so we're really excited about our outreach program the opportunities to provide school divisions but wherever going forward is so critical and this program can really support educators and school divisions next i'm going to jump into our professional learning program and this program

[00:36:06] was spun up initially at the same time as the outreach program in 2012. this is consisting of free training for all virginia public school educators again at no cost our catalog is available 24 7 365. some asynchronous some synchronous offerings available and again it's not just virtual virginia that is creating content it's all of our partners and educators across the state at the department the canvas lms visty vascd virginia museum of fine arts school divisions are creating content and making it available on the system as well and we're partnering with a lot lot of Virginia colleges and universities. Some of the exciting things we are getting into our

[00:36:45] professional learning program is micro-credentials, credentials, and badging. We recognize that that is a big need across the state, and we have a couple pilots going and a couple programs getting ready to launch next year that we're really excited about in those spaces. One of the benefits of the statewide learning management system is we're now able to connect educators across the state, and in our statewide professional learning network, we are just getting started on this program. It's very exciting. It's a community of all Virginia public educators. It's a space for them to access discussions, workshops, statewide professional learning offerings. They can join

[00:37:24] user groups. So all the biology teachers in the state can join the biology teacher user group. All the grade level 10 teachers can join the grade 10 teacher user group. And there they can find specific targeted professional learning opportunities available to them in one space. So when they log into the LMS, it's right there for them.

[00:37:42] It's a statewide professional learning network, and they're able to easily access professional learning opportunities that are updated regularly and available mostly at no cost to them as well. And again, these are both synchronous and asynchronous professional learning opportunities for educators who want to do them at their own time or wish to attend things like webinars or live trainings.

[00:38:03] So our professional learning program has really grown over the last several years from just teaching that one course back when we started in 2012 to now expanding to a much wider catalog and a variety of opportunities available. The fourth program I want to talk about today is our summer learning program, and we're heading into summer learning season.

[00:38:25] This program is picking up a lot of steam right now and enrollments are coming in. What we do offer during those summer months is enrichment camps in grades K-5 in world languages, Chinese, Spanish, and French, and also STEM and core academics. And then we offer courses in grades 6 through 12.

[00:38:41] This summer, 90 courses are going to be available. We do have two cohorts to accommodate differing school calendars across the state, one beginning in early June for those earlier start divisions, and another in mid-June for those near Labor Day and post Labor Day divisions. So, again, being flexible and accommodating those summer learning needs for a variety of learners across the state.

[00:39:04] So those are our four programs, the K-12 instruction, summer learning, outreach, and professional learning. Obviously, we've learned a lot over the last several years. So some of the most important things that we've learned is Virtual Virginia's K-12 model is unique.

[00:39:22] Our opportunities for synchronous are unique in that not every provider does offer as much synchronous as we do. we do feel it's important to provide those opportunities for learners. The needs of K-12 learners across the Commonwealth are changing and they continue to evolve. They're not as they were a few months ago, as a matter of fact. The investment into teacher recruitment and training has been critical for us. Our teachers are highly qualified, they are trained, and that investment that we make into them has started to show because the positive vibe around virtual Virginia right now,

[00:39:59] they are our backbone are those teachers the statewide lms and the needs for a school division lms is growing you know a lot of school divisions jumped onto an lms during the pandemic but now they're starting to realize long term what the affordances are that learning management system can provide them and connecting professional learning to larger systems is critical larger systems are difficult to change but if we support educators through professional learning we can help meet those evolving needs as they are going forward.

[00:40:31] The last thing I want to put here about lessons learned is I kind of feel we're just getting started. You know, I think for five years, we're going to look back and say, as John referenced, this is an inflection point. This is a new starting point for us. You know, we've all learned these things. Our whole world changed very, very quickly. And now we're just getting started on how to support learners and families in these new needs that are coming across the post pandemic.

[00:40:56] a lot of things that we've also learned is some of the existing research in fact most of it is six through twelve so we want to be a part of that k-5 research here in the commonwealth we want to show that virtual virginia has been participating k-12 online instruction and we want to be part of that new research that focuses on the k-12 going forward and there are of course challenges in a program of this size and this scope one is our flexible staffing when we enroll students we try I just remain with the SOQ/SOA.

[00:41:32] However, enrollments come, enrollments go, students transition back. So it's difficult for us to maintain a static teacher load, a teacher ratio, but we do pretty well. And there are other challenges too, misconceptions. One is screen time.

[00:41:49] You know, I'm a father of three and I understand that screen time is very much a real thing, but not all screen time is created equal. If students are engaged and they're producing, that's good screen time. So we recognize that while screen time is definitely a focus, definitely a priority, we want to make sure that we're distinguishing between good and bad screen time.

[00:42:11] Another is that teachers are exhausted, tired of technology. They feel overworked. We hear that sometimes. You know, I see teachers rolling up their sleeves. That's what I see. I think they're ready to embrace technology, and they're ready to see how it can make their lives simpler and how they can utilize automation and utilize these systems to support teacher learning and student learning.

[00:42:32] You know, teachers want to know how students are doing. They also want to know how they're doing, and these tools can support them in that way. Another misconception is that online learning doesn't work. You know, and that's not necessarily accurate. Bad online learning doesn't work. We agree with that.

[00:42:47] But sound instructional design, sound strategies, and sound approach can be effective for learners. One of the other challenges is, we've talked about it a couple times already, is the synchronous and asynchronous requirements. You know, it's difficult because all learners are different.

[00:43:03] And K-2, 3-5, 6-8, 9-12, they're going to have different needs as far as synchronous and asynchronous. We will continue to support, again, data reporting. As I referenced earlier with our MSC report, we are thrilled about that. We want to continue to be part of that K-12 research.

[00:43:21] And, of course, supporting blended and personalized learning going forward. Virtual Virginia continues to be on the forefront of that. And, again, as we go forward, we expect growth in all of our programs, all four, the K-12 instruction, the outreach professional learning and summer session programs going into next year.

[00:43:42] Thank you. - Thank you so much, Dr. Mott. And Ms. Hamlin, actually, if you could just stay for a moment, if it's okay. I noticed that we lost John. I'd actually like to pause and, oh, there he is. Oh, okay.

[00:43:57] - Yeah, no, you didn't lose me. I just, I have to get ready for a flight momentarily and leave my hotel room. So I was doing some cleanup in the background. Sorry for going off video. - Oh, no worries. Well, I actually think given the length of the presentations, it might be appropriate at this moment, Ms. Hamlin, if you're okay, if we can pause and invite the board to ask questions.

[00:44:21] Dr. Mott, there was a lot of information being covered around Virtual Virginia, as well as the comments that were made by Mr. Watson. So if we could pause here and just open the floor for questions, comments, reactions. That was a very comprehensive overview of something I know we've, I've heard a lot

about virtual Virginia during my short time on the board and appreciate having a chance to kind of get more nuanced and understanding its underpinnings.

[00:44:50] So questions, Dr. Duran? - Thank you for the very thorough presentation. And I know a lot about virtual Virginia, but I learned a few more things today. Just two quick questions. One is really around, as you said, the needs of students you're seeing is growing in terms of the population you're serving.

[00:45:09] One concern I've had and I've heard from many parents in particular is for English language learner and special education students having access to virtual Virginia. They're not able to get all of their needs met that way. And there's oftentimes a desire for some to have virtual opportunities, but they feel that it's a barrier for students not to be able to access through those needs that they have.

[00:45:31] So can you tell me a little bit about what you've learned in that space, what you've done to address that need and what you're planning to do? Because it is something I hear quite a bit from parents over and over again about their desire and their understanding of the Virtual Virginia program to be very meaningful, but yet not for their student.

[00:45:46] If they have an EL, particularly beginning learners, or for some of our students, our parents that have students with disabilities who don't have the services that are needed to their IEP. So can you share a little bit about that? Absolutely. So, you know, at Virtual Virginia, we're committed to providing opportunities for all learners. And traditionally, when the program was smaller in scale, you know, we didn't have as many needs, right?

[00:46:07] The needs were more limited at that point. They're more targeted. And now that we've grown, I'd love to sit here and say, oh, we have this figured out. But we are still learning as well in that respect. Now, how do we meet needs of learners now with special accommodations or English language supports is we do rely on that partnership with the school.

[00:46:25] So we still rely on those student services being provided by the school division, whether they need to be in person or online. and we've experienced a lot of success with that this year and last year but obviously you know as this grows it becomes more mainstream we're all as a collective gonna have to work to find solutions there because we need to make these opportunities available wholesale and then one follow-up is kind of connected to that so i noticed that i'm familiar with the program that each school has a mentor or counselor that supports each student and now given what you just said if a student is an english learner or a student disability what kind of access to the school have to what students are

[00:47:01] learning in virtual virginia what kind of data to know what they're doing so for example if i'm an english learner teacher supporting a student in virtual virginia i need to understand how that child's doing what they're doing in those courses so if i'm an educator or that mentor that you described what kind of access would i have to be able to support the student if i'm a school division person okay great question so yeah essentially the counselor and mentor role can be anybody the school assigns right it could be a case manager or it could be a special education teacher locally we do also provide additional roles where we can bring those personnel at the school into the course and it's all secure so they just have access to that one student and

[00:47:37] not the other students in the course so they can see the live instruction they can see the recorded instruction they can access student performance data as well so we do fold in and bake in those

supports locally thank you and i appreciate that for those questions i mean i think as we're thinking about this is to my colleagues and to state superintendent as we're thinking about any kind of guidance regulations around virtual learning i think it's an important part that we consider for our students with disabilities and english learners what kind of guidance and direction will give to make sure that if it is the school divisions or the local school that is providing that support as you described that's very clearly outlined

[00:48:14] and that there's clear supports because i imagine some school divisions and some schools can do that very well and others may not be able to do that so i think we need to be cognizant if we're thinking about this as a statewide program and a statewide effort, which I really support and I'm excited about, that we don't lose sight of those learners who could potentially not get the supports that they need.

[00:48:33] Or, you know, oftentimes it falls through the cracks then because if it's seen that the school division is supposed to provide that and then the school division, I think the virtual Virginia is providing that, and then who's in the middle is our parent who is struggling with their child not getting their needs met. So I think it's an important point for us to consider for our state superintendent and The state of my colleagues on the board to think about how do we give that very specific guidance?

[00:48:56] Very very clear the expectation for those students if what I just heard you say correct me if I'm wrong That a lot of that is a reliance on the local school division to provide that support and use indicated It's been working well in most cases I want to make sure that works well in every case because there should not be one Student with disability or one English learner who does not have their needs met through this partnership. It's a great partnership it's a great possibility but we have to make sure i think that those students are constantly being met because ultimately it then falls upon the parents to be in the middle of the two and that should not be on a parent to be trying to fight for their child to get their needs met when we

[00:49:34] have a great system in place so that's my comments to our state superintendent and my colleagues here thank you thanks so much i know mr watson only has a couple of minutes left so if there are any questions for him I want to make sure he has an opportunity to address that any questions Miss Holton and then dr. Davis ball first thank you both for those great presentations as as my colleague Francisco said I'm I thought I knew a lot and I learned a lot more today John to you two questions really I'll

[00:50:09] combine them in light of the time one is obviously from your perch you have the opportunity to watch what's going on all across the country be candid with us what are our strengths and opportunities here in Virginia especially as we think about policy around virtual education and maybe this is a subcategory of that one of the questions that's come up is staffing ratios and I heard you say that it can be the right staffing ratio might be higher or lower or just different for virtual education but as we go about thinking about and I I hear Brian telling us that in Virtual Virginia,

[00:50:47] they're adhering to our regular staffing ratio requirements for brick-and-mortar schools, but that question has been raised by some of our private online school providers. What is the right step?

[00:51:03] How should we go about addressing the question of staffing ratios? So any insight on any of that would be great. - Sure, I'll address this. second question first. I think the way that Dr. Mott talked about the the ratio question is exactly I think that's a really good situation. What I heard him say was we're not required necessarily to do this but here's what we do and we report on it and and that's the approach

that I would suggest you you take or at least strongly consider with all the online and hybrid schools to say what

[00:51:42] are you doing and if different than the standards, tell us why and tell us why you think that works. The reason that I think that approach can work, I referenced this briefly, but let me just go into a bit more detail. We see a lot of online and hybrid schools. What they do is they have a person in a role that typically does not exist in a mainstream school, and And this is a person who is deeply knowledgeable about their set of students, which means in turn that every student in this school has somebody at this school who is deeply knowledgeable about that student.

[00:52:20] And when I say deeply knowledgeable, I mean both academically, they know exactly where this student is on an academic path towards wherever they want to go. This person understands what the student plans, let's say this is a high school student for instance, this person understands what the student is trying to achieve in high school, they're planning to do next whether it's a job military college etc what their interests are that are driving what they're doing academically and what some of their challenges may be whether they're health related or otherwise of course to the extent that students and families will want to share that information now some people say back to me well we have guidance counselors for

[00:52:59] that and my answer is if you look at national typical national ratios for guidance counselors and I don't know what they are in Virginia but if you at the typical national ratios for guidance counselors they are in the hundreds of students and there's no way that the type of relationship that i just described can be delved into deeply with somebody who has hundreds of students so i just use that example because what that's done is it's bringing some somebody in who is at a very very different uh a very different type of role than is than is difficult and as i referenced in my opening comments sometimes that's a teacher and so what that means is the teachers who are doing this are are playing this role are typically

[00:53:39] not going to have as many students in their classes because they're taking on this really important role other schools are creatively looking at ways to work with teachers and often actually working in teams i'll mention something knowing that i can't get people into it but but the analogy i'm using is there's a lot of healthcare systems that are now using doctors physicians assistants and nurses in different ways which frees up what the doctors can do while using these other really important professionals in different ways i think there's an analogy here to education actually i know there's an analogy to education and so i would

[00:54:14] just my suggestion would be to set expectations parameters look at outcomes and then give divisions and individual schools some flexibility around that just to briefly touch on your first question about Virginia. I think the obvious thing is the fact that you've got a program like Virtual Virginia, which has the experience that it has. It's working across supplemental and full-time students as well. And Virginia is one of a relatively small number of states

[00:54:49] that has supported a state program at the level, created something at the level of the Virtual Virginia now that to be clear that doesn't mean that there's not a really important role for the individual school divisions and individual schools as well but it means that you have a state level organization that can both provide support resources training all those sorts of things and I think can can better help others at the state level understand these issues that are happening among the school districts and or divisions I should say and and I try to reference that in my comments as well the idea that what i think you want to do is and by the way i have

[00:55:28] nieces and nephews in the virginia public school system so i i have some insights into it it's a very high quality system and so what you've got is you've got innovation bubbling up from the individual schools and the divisions and finding the ways to marry that with the the expertise and quality coming out of virtual virginia i think is the opportunity thank you very helpful dr davis Thank you Dr. Mann thank you Mr. Watson for sharing your information and thank you for the

[00:56:03] compliment we have very hard-working teachers in our schools as well as division leaders all the way up to the department of ed but my question is is for Dr. Mott and I don't know if I missed this Dr. Mott but something near and dear to k-5 education is career exploration and assessing student interest can you tell me if you mentioned or and i missed it the method that you're using to guide students through that process yeah absolutely is there a program you use yeah that's part of our partnership with schools we still rely on the local school that enrolling school to do

[00:56:40] the the counseling services the student services so those are still managed through their their uh enrolling school their local school division okay thank you sure dr anderson yeah mr watson if you have time for another question before you have to scoot to catch your plane it's really for both but just maybe to hear your perspective first so teacher attraction retention is a is a challenge that we know we're facing uh an in-person learning standpoint i'm just really curious kind of what what that landscape looks like from a teacher retention attraction standpoint in a virtual world especially post-pandemic where everybody or a lot of folks are very interested

[00:57:17] in working from home curious if there's challenges there if there's an overabundance what does that look like at the national level and then in the at the common law level it's a great question uh and i want to caution i'm not familiar with data on this and i always want to say okay here's what we know from actual data and here's what we're hearing anecdotally and this is firmly in the anecdotal uh section uh we are generally hearing that online and hybrid schools are mostly not having the same issues with teacher attraction and retention. And I believe that's for a few

[00:57:54] reasons. One, as you referenced, teachers have a fair bit more flexibility and there's some elements of that that they like in terms of that working environment. The second thing is over the decades that I've been in this field, I have seen this exact trajectory among so many educators, so many professionals and by the way i'll mention this also applies to my wife who's a university professor who started teaching her first online course about five years ago many teachers when they start teaching online they don't they're skeptical they're not convinced that they can

[00:58:30] connect as closely online as they can with students face-to-face and then they try it and it may take a year it may take a couple of years but they get to the point where i i can't tell you how many times i've heard this from an experienced teacher i now know my online students better than i ever knew my face-to-face students and the reason is because there's a couple reasons one is they recognize that some of the students who are shy in a face-to-face classroom really flourish in the online environment second thing is students nowadays are incredibly comfortable they tend to be incredibly comfortable in the digital environment generally educationally or

[00:59:05] otherwise and so they are much more open to sharing in a digital environment sometimes than they are face-to-face the third element is that teachers are able to really focus on each student individually and that's the those are the teachers who who do really well and who love being in an online or a hybrid

environment final thing i'll say about this is because teachers are are they're taking a very different approach to teaching than being in a mainstream school where they are going

[00:59:41] where they have to go class to class often with 20 to 30 students in each class they have more time to work together to engage in their own professional learning to focus as i said on individual students and so one of the things that we hear repeatedly from teachers is just a and again this is anecdotal but a much higher level of job satisfaction when they are at an online or a hybrid school or a program like virtual virginia great yeah i'd love to hear the same at commonwealth level again i'm i want to be mindful of dr watson's time i don't know when

[01:00:16] he has to scoot no we're very uh we're very uh thankful for the teachers that want to come to virtual virginia and we are very selective as a result we are able to take time train teachers before we actually bring them on board make sure they're a good fit to have them demonstrate how they feel virtual learning should be and how the virtual virginia way of virtual learning should be and this group that we have they are they're amazing they're amazing educators they're energized every day some of the things john mentioned they're collaborating with each other more than they did in a face-to-face environment some of the things john references well when i

[01:00:51] taught face-to-face i wasn't the best teacher in my hall you know there were other people that i was inspired by and that's how i think teachers get a lot of their inspirations from others so that communicating working with their groups they're using technology tools to do that now right they're they're doing it more efficiently and more often. And so not only are you developing that great work culture, you're developing that great professional camaraderie that you need to have to have a really good faculty. So at Virtual Virginia, again, we are very, very pleased with the recruitment effort. And for me, large scale, when you look at it, if we have a lot of

[01:01:27] teachers who want to teach virtually, and we have a lot of needs that exist in in-person learning, we should be connecting those two we should be connecting our in-person needs with teachers who want to stay teachers and so that's something to think about so one follow-on question you had mentioned during your presentation that one of your requirements is that you can't as a full-time teacher you can't have a contract in place with the public school because of available you want to make sure they're available but then from a part-time standpoint i'm is that still the case even for your part-time teachers because again i'm kind of getting back to uh from a recruitment standpoint kind of benefiting both sides the virtual and in person when there's more options

[01:02:06] for teachers to say hey i could i i do want to do i do want to be a teacher but i need to work at home part-time and you know unless i work at the school part-time and then work for virtual virginia part-time is that still a requirement that they even at a part-time level they don't have that option part-time educators may be employed with a school division okay so they work for us part-time but again it's all about the best teacher sure if we have an educator who maybe just wants to be part-time and and we find that they're a good fit for our program we'll bring them on in a part-time capacity and make sure they're out there able to impact kids so thank you okay we're going to turn to thank you so much dr mott stay around there could be a couple of other questions

[01:02:46] as we uh get to um miss hamlin thank you so much for your patience we're delighted to have you please and john if you need to scoot we understand thank you so much for your time this afternoon - Yep, really valuable, thank you.

[01:03:01] - Well, good afternoon, everyone. I'm so pleased to be here today. Before I start my presentation, I'd like to address that last question about teacher retention because I am aware that there is a research study being done by Michigan Virtual, their research institute, specifically on the topic of teacher retention.

[01:03:21] So I think that's due out in June. So I'm sure Brian will have access to that and would be happy to share that as that study comes out. and I think Brian and his team were maybe part of that data collection on that. So I won't take a lot of your time.

[01:03:37] Again, I thank you for the invitation to share a little bit about the work of state virtual schools across the country as you embark on this important work. And I will compliment you that it is important work and worth the time that you're taking to explore that.

[01:03:57] The state virtual schools and all their work to enhance and expand opportunities for all students, whether that's urban or rural. I hope this information is helpful as you begin exploring the issue that you're here today for. I am the director for the Virtual Learning Leadership Alliance, and that is a nonprofit educational organization comprised of 20 state virtual schools or large consortiums that offer online learning courses and services to support their partner divisions

[01:04:31] districts in their state and i liked how dr mott emphasized the partnership model because i think that's true for all of our state virtual schools the student remains locally enrolled in the public or private school and is just getting a supplement or enhanced courses through their state virtual school partner our association started in 2019 really as a means for this group to collaborate and share best practices about online learning with each other the mission of our organization

[01:05:07] is to strengthen online learning through leadership and advocacy initiatives the expertise of this group running successful online programs in their state for many over 20 years and i did hear uh dr mott mentioned uh virgin virtual virginia's been around or some version of that for 40 years, I believe he said. But this group has experience and provides an opportunity to really lead and support those just getting started in online learning offerings to meet student needs.

[01:05:43] Collectively, our members serve close to a million annual supplemental course enrollments each year, and that is partnering with about 2,600 divisions throughout the country. This number that I mentioned the close to a million enrollments does not include the enrollment from divisions that utilize the state's virtual school the state virtual schools lms i should say and the courses that they've developed i know dr mott mentioned the virginia outreach program many of our state

[01:06:22] virtual schools provide a similar service where they are just helping support local divisions to stand up their own program. In 2018-19, our VLLA membership, along with Quality Matters, and this is an organization that certifies quality online courses, and Dr. or Mr. Watson's group, the Digital Learning Collaborative, launched a project to review, revise, and publish the national standards for quality online learning. With the assistance of over 200 volunteer

[01:07:02] researchers and practitioners these standards were published and through the creative commons license and made available to the field of online learning the standards include quality online programs what quality online teaching looks like and quality online courses and these three standards sets provide a framework for schools divisions state agencies and other interested programs wanting to improve their online program since the standards were released i know the staff

[01:07:39] from virtual virginia have developed many resources and provided guidance not only internally to their own staff but to others other states and divisions implementing the national standards for quality and this includes leadership in course design what makes that quality course engaging and effective for student learning to teacher onboarding and professional learning all the top topics i heard dr mott mentioned in his presentation he also shared or dr mott shared some impressive data

[01:08:14] highlighting the impact virtual virginia is having on expanding learning opportunities for students across the commonwealth similar data is collected annually by all the state virtual schools across the country to track not only enrollment but courses offered divisions and schools served professional learning opportunities and other data makes it helpful to track over time and improve our work and guide our work a section was added in the data collection instrument

[01:08:49] last year when we were we were really in the midst of the pandemic we wanted to get a glimpse of what was the impact that state virtual schools are having in light of the pandemic how how is their support being utilized. The data not only provided growth as Dr. Mott shared in online courses and teachers hired to service and support those expanded enrollments, but we also saw the addition of the K-5 online courses and programming and professional learning opportunities to educators

[01:09:29] outside their own staff. These are two programs that Virtual Virginia has had in place for a while, as Dr. Mott mentioned. So they took a real leadership role in helping these other state virtual schools get up to speed on offering a K-5 program, as well as the expanded professional development that we saw across the nation. In conclusion, I'd like to refer back to, and I think

[01:10:03] Dr. Mott did too. John's statement where he mentioned is a inflection point that we're seeing in education. We've been through the pandemic, we've experienced good and bad with remote learning, but I think our best path forward includes tapping into the experience of individuals and programs like Virtual Virginia as we explored how to improve our educational system and virtual learning.

[01:10:32] again thanks for the opportunity to share the work of the state virtual schools and their efforts to enhance educational opportunities for all thank you thank you so much for being here and sharing those comments are there questions for um miss hamlin dr durham thank you miss hamlin similar question i asked dr mott what are you seeing at the national level in terms of best practices for supporting our english learner students engaged in virtual learning and also our students with disabilities who are engaged what are some of the best practices and any suggestions

[01:11:09] that you provide to uh members of your organization about how to better support them well i would respond very similar to dr mott i think that is an area that we are constantly focused on as well as accessibility i wouldn't say anyone has it perfect yet it is an area that we continue to grow in the partnership going back to emphasizing the partnership that is true for all of our state virtual schools they do partner and it is a a joint effort in servicing those

[01:11:43] students that have other needs i do see many of the enhancements and course design and content being able to as we move forward better support those ell learners as well as the accessibility needed for our special needs population i did have one question if there aren't other questions i want to make sure other board members all right um miss hamlin i i wanted to understand the

[01:12:17] standards that you referenced um the translation of the standards in my mind speak to um the approach to using technology or teaching through uh virtual means as sort of the the focus of those

standards and then uh states are able to use their own standards of learning as the content basis for um infusing what is actually taught but that your standards are really more about the approach to using technology for teaching is is that the right

[01:12:56] way to think about what those standards represent and then secondly i was curious about the k5 side of things particularly uh given some of the comments that were made by mr watson around young children in particular and and to what extent would you say across the states that there is real activity in that area that happened prior let's not focus on covet because i know you know during the pandemic everybody had to figure out a way to make learning possible but

[01:13:30] i am curious prior to the pandemic what was the sort of state of things with respect to k5 and and virtual learning across these state systems? - Sure, both excellent questions.

[01:13:45] I'll address the national standards for quality first. Those do not, those support your content standards. So in within all three standard sets, whether it's courses, teaching or programs, there is the alignment to the local state standards.

[01:14:05] So it's really not looking at the content standards. What it's truly looking at is what are the best practices? What are we looking for and training our teachers? For example, the quality online teaching standards. What does our professional learning need to look like?

[01:14:21] What are the things that we need to be monitoring with our teachers to ensure their pedagogy is effective in an online environment? For example, the whole area of engagement has been very important, has always been important, has come to the to the forefront when many were not seeing that during the pandemic so within one whole standards that there are several indicators along with examples and explanations of how that online teacher can best support engagement in his or her classroom not necessarily seeing each other

[01:15:00] face to face so it's a whole set of different um strategies that can be used to ensure that that student stays engaged in the content is communicate communication is ongoing effective feedback you think about you're not in the classroom that feedback with the student is so important so they're able to improve and enhance their learning so i just kind of focused in on the online teaching there is a whole set of standards about what an on effective quality online course looks life and then if you're looking at a program from staffing to finances to your mission statement

[01:15:39] government that is kind of that is what's covered in the online program standards um any questions before i move on to the k-5 around those the standards for quality no that was clear thank you and so i think that would be a great resource as as you move forward with your work and as i mentioned i know west virginia i'm sorry virginia has been a leader with us in developing a number of resources that they've shared out on how to introduce the standards to their teachers how they

[01:16:14] use it to to monitor their teachers develop their courses so forth regarding k-5 for many of our state virtual schools k-5 was was was new in the last couple years most of them were middle school and high school as far as courses offered a majority of them are now looking because of interest and requests to the lower grades i do see in just talking with our membership and what they're looking at from a k-5 they are looking at more synchronous opportunities

[01:16:53] on a daily basis to meet with those students unlike maybe middle or high school that is a key point that they're building into their models and and a lower student to teacher ratio when we're looking at

k-5 so those are the two things that would stand out that um i think are maybe a little different as they design their elementary programs thank you miss holton thank you miss hamlin and really appreciate your uh presentation and your patience uh my question it's a variation

[01:17:33] of what I asked Mr. Watson, but what advice do you have for us as we think about regulatory policy around virtual education, and I think particularly with respect to private entities offering full-time online school options that our K-12 divisions may be contracting with.

[01:17:56] What do we put into state policy that will help them perform at their best? And are there states that are good models around that? You know, how do we help promote the kind of standards, high quality standards you're talking about through policy with all our virtual education providers in Virginia? You know, and we do have other states looking at that. I know Texas and Connecticut, Maryland, there are other states in the union really looking at a similar work that you're doing now um leaning as i said on that expertise for so

[01:18:36] many it is new but you know what are the lessons learned what have many of the programs throughout the country in the 20 years that um have been operating and providing services and growing and expanding uh leaning on some of of the i guess past practices that come out of their experience would we would be one thing i think flexibility both dr mott and john lawson mentioned in this role is having that inflexibility as far as looking at several things whether it's

[01:19:13] synchronous asynchronous student teacher ratio because they are so different not only from the teacher perspective that john really honed in on but but even the course itself and the grade level can make a big difference on that i think just the focusing on the quality uh is is is the key uh as far as looking at a policy that you might look at explore if i may follow up i hear you and i hear everybody telling us flexibility and i get that but i will say that our traditional model of

[01:19:52] helping contribute to quality is doesn't it isn't necessarily a flexibility-based approach so we do prescribed teacher student ratios and so I'm hearing you say in this environment and I'm hearing the others tell us that that may make less sense in in the virtual environment and I get that but I you know how do we separate the wheat from the chaff and I do know from the literature I've read that there are online virtual schools that are doing great work and there are folks that are doing terrible work so how do we how would we interact how do we use

[01:20:28] regulation to or who do we when you say we listen to them I that makes sense how do we make sure we're listening to the folks who are doing great work and then how do we structure regulations that help promote that and you know and I think looking at the data the outcomes of students the success of the students I concur with the importance of the teacher that in some programs that is not emphasized as much as it is in many of of the quality programs is that center point of the

[01:21:06] teacher ensuring there are expectations it's not it's not the wild west that there are training and expectations that those teachers follow someone is monitoring that teacher as far as you know what kind of feedback are they bringing how often are they communicating with the students those are the kinds of guidelines and really looking at what makes that success and ensuring that is kind of within the policy guidelines thank you and it's also very helpful to hear other states that are wrestling with this because that's a learning opportunity certainly other

[01:21:44] questions i did have one more for dr mott i noticed you presented information on ap outcomes and i noticed you said that the there's a process to improve how we understand student outcome in the space verifying the data that it is self-report and that there's their efforts underway to do that i was curious to try and translate what that really means in terms of outcome data that we

[01:22:18] have on students that are being served through virtual virginia beyond the ap i know there are other ways that we look at outcomes and i was just curious about what might you say around that well Well, you know, having data is critical, right?

[01:22:36] It informs everything we do. And for, as I referenced earlier, the dueling systems, we have a registration system at Virtual Virginia. We have a state longitudinal data system. They weren't talking. So school divisions would go in, register students for our courses. They would complete courses, but the STI may be off by a number, right?

[01:22:55] And so at the end of the year, when we ran that compliance, we would find there was no in-person test for this individual student because the STI didn't match identically. the school had all the reporting the school still reported the transcript the the sol assessment grading things like that so the school still had the reporting we would have to reach out to them previously and say how did the student do on this exam or you know ap sol and so forth that isn't efficient and that's not sustainable as this program scales and grows so now we do submit as i said that master schedule report which is cross-checked and validated with the slds going

[01:23:33] forward so we do have more accurate reliable information um and i did the ap exam scores we use those were based on the college board's new system where they tie the student to the institution they received the instruction so they recognized this was a challenge nationwide and part of the ap classroom was bringing that data back to us so um again early results positive and uh our faculty and staff you know they live with that chip on their shoulder that you know this data from you know 2019 we don't have it all right so they work within that space and they're really thrilled that this msc report is going to bring some uh more cross-checking and validation of enrollment data

[01:24:12] for sure and the and the retention question that dr anderson asked do you all track a retention of the teachers that are teaching in virtual virginia do you all have a way of understanding what your numbers are oh yeah we absolutely and with the growth we've had we're now several hundred teachers strong um and we we staff based on enrollment and we just did our intent to return and this is a little bit behind the curtain we only had two who elected not to return out of hundreds so you know they feel supported they feel engaged some of the stuff that uh teachers have to do like i mentioned

[01:24:48] we leverage automation we leverage a lot of that for them so they do have more free time to get to know their students to interact with the parents and guardians to provide additional support as needed so we're using technology to benefit instruction in ways that these teachers haven't seen before right because we've been doing this for 10 years we've been doing this at a high level for since 2006 and so you know a lot of the challenges school divisions had when they went online in 2020 we had those challenges in 2018 i mean 2008 2007 we developed solutions for them miss holden you reminded me i forgot to say i think i've told you this before but i one of my

[01:25:27] children all of whom came up through public education of Virginia one of my children took a virtual Virginia Chinese class in middle school many many many moons ago so it was early but you have a great experience thank you it's it's we've learned so much and you know it's it's been a long road I've been

here since 2007 at virtual Virginia I started off as a teacher here and a lot has changed then and I'm you know if I could encapsulate the 16 years I've been here the first seven eight years were all about challenges right it was we were figuring out what

[01:26:03] we were doing and schools were figuring out how to leverage virtual virginia the last seven or eight years were really about growth and sustainability they truly were like incremental growth and then of course the last three years has been quite uh amazing i think the next seven eight years are really going to be focused on quality or we need to be focused on quality going forward because there's just so many options out there now how do we distinguish high quality from from from a program that isn't high quality so that's our focus internally is is how do we ensure that we're providing the best possible opportunities for learners okay uh we're going

[01:26:38] to hear i think uh superintendent has a comment and then we'll wrap it up yeah so first of all thank you um to all three of the presenters and thank you to the board members for asking such thoughtful and deep questions um as i kind of synthesize all of the information that i heard especially Dr. Duran. What just bubbled to the surface for me, and Dr. Maude, as you talked about, like, look, it's been incredible what's happened over the last three years, and looking into the future, how do we harness that, and how do we unleash everything that was good about it,

[01:27:16] and how do we improve on everything that maybe was a little more challenging as we responded to a crisis worldwide and um and i i think part of the answer is you've given look we're really vested in this we're going to keep improving we're putting quality uh increasing access but not forgetting about quality and in fact improving quality at the very forefront of those conversations so um and you and i haven't talked very much uh uh we have via other people because i've been asking lots of questions. But I know that I will be really interested moving forward with what is

[01:27:54] our plan? Like what is our matrix for making decisions over the next seven or eight years? Where do we really want to lean in and lead the nation? Where do we really want to lean in and put our chips in terms of quality and access? And again, Dr. Duran, thank you so much for just kind of bringing that to the surface today. But I know that that's one thing we'll be working on as an agency is just really understanding what is our plan. We don't want to always be responding.

[01:28:23] We don't want to be trailing. We want to be leading in this work. And we have all of the makings for it. We're poised to do that. And so I guess our commitment to you is to make sure that we do have a plan that's articulated, that's thoughtful. And that may already exist, Whether that's sort of in your team's brain power or in the way that you work and what you think should happen.

[01:28:50] But I want to make sure that as we go forward, we have an articulated plan that is backed up by all of the wonderful data that you shared today and driven by all of the data that's available that maybe we didn't share today. No, absolutely. And you've been busy. So, no, I think the, you know, this program, which all you heard today, it isn't, we didn't just spin it up.

[01:29:12] It's not me. efforts over decades and collections of people in the room you know everybody's putting forth this program and we're really proud of the footprint obviously but we now recognize that in 2022 we've outgrown that footprint a little bit and there's a lot more that we can be doing so we look forward to it awesome thank you miss hamlin thank you so much for your time this afternoon and sharing with us we certainly look forward to uh staying in touch as the board certainly undertakes the work it needs to do in the space regarding regulations so thank you and good luck on your work awesome

[01:29:51] so are we good to march forward or take shall we take a five-minute break yeah yes we're going to take a break we're going to take a restroom break we'll be back at a quarter of three

[01:38:32] a pleasure to have um with us for this next segment amy or emily are we okay to start okay great we actually have um amy sepka who is our director of accountability along of course with shelly loving rider who is here and we're going to spend some time talking about um chronic absenteeism you know we have an action on the agenda tomorrow so we're delighted that you're here this afternoon to take us through a presentation where we can have some questions learn a little bit more about the issues at hand thank you good afternoon vice president man and

[01:39:12] superintendent baylow and board members as dr mann stated tomorrow we will be bringing in front of the board a proposal to adopt special provisions regarding the use of the chronic absenteeism indicator for accreditation year 2223 so today i wanted to go over some background information on chronic absenteeism how it's used in our accreditation system and a review of the proposal that will will be going over tomorrow I'll start out by defining

[01:39:51] chronic absenteeism most researchers define chronic absenteeism as a student who misses 10% or more of the school year for any reason and that includes excused or unexcused absences and Virginia does use this definition and in Virginia we do calculate chronic absenteeism based on the number of days a student is enrolled in the school so for instance of a typical school year if it's 180 days and a student is enrolled all 180 days once they miss 18 or more school

[01:40:30] days, they are considered chronically absent. That is approximately two days per month, if we looked at it that way, or more than three weeks per school year. Historically, there have been other measures that have been used to measure attendance. The average daily attendance rate used to be used. Truancy was measured, which is a measure of unexcused absences but none of them really gave a real picture of the total picture of how many days a

[01:41:05] student was absent from school so um quite a few years ago there started to be some research that started to point to the detrimental effects of absences on student achievement so this prompted the uscd in i believe it was in 2013-14 to start collecting chronic absenteeism data in the civil rights data collection and that started to paint this full picture of students attendance in school and when the scope of that data came out it was really a wake-up call and it was a

[01:41:45] call to action i believe in that study they found that approximately close to 7 million students were chronically absent across the country which was about 14 of students so of course after that there started to be a lot of ensuing research that that was trying to determine what were the impacts of chronic absenteeism on student outcomes so chronic absenteeism has been determined to be an important and reliable uh indicator of student engagement and research does demonstrate

[01:42:20] that chronic absenteeism is a strong predictor of whether a student will be successful or not so first of all the prevalence of chronic absenteeism across the grades tends to be u-shaped so it will decrease from kindergarten through fifth grade and then as students go through middle school and high school the the chronic absenteeism goes up secondly there is evidence that low income and minority students are more likely to be excessively absent from school than others

[01:42:56] and the there's just so much research out there but other studies have shown that by the time students get in grade three those that have been chronically absent are below the proficiency levels in

reading and mathematics they have lower achievement levels in both elementary and middle school chronically absent students are more likely to be retained and they're also more likely to drop out of high school outside of academics these students feel a greater sense of alienation from

[01:43:34] classmates teachers and schools these students have been found to have larger frequencies of negative interactions and social disengagement when they do return to school these students are also less likely to enroll in college and for those that do enroll in college many of them don't persist through their post-secondary studies after that data collection in 2013-14 when there was that kind of call to action virginia did collaborate with an organization called

[01:44:12] attendance works and that's an organization that works with states and also on the national level to try to make sure that better policies and practices are in place to improve student attendance so the uh virginia did work with attendance works and created a set of online training modules to help schools identify strategies and implement strategies that can improve attendance and we have a very extensive list of resources and those modules on our website so

[01:44:49] that is a strength of virginia that we do really have a lot of resources putting the preventive measures in place that we have is important because the effects of chronic absenteeism is not irreversible so there has been research that's shown for example that students who are chronically absent in kindergarten but then improve their attendance can close the achievement gaps later and research has also demonstrated that good attendance among disadvantaged students

[01:45:23] can help ease the close the achievement gap in early grades so these preventative measures are very important and which just goes to bolster the idea that we should really be monitoring the the chronic absenteeism rates.

[01:45:42] So when we revised our standards of accreditation and our school accreditation model in 2017, we tried to create a model that provided a more comprehensive look at school quality.

[01:45:58] And one of the indicators that we did put into our accreditation model is chronic absenteeism. And based on the relationship between school attendance and student achievement, and the ability for chronic absenteeism to really differentiate between schools, it was selected as a measure of student engagement.

[01:46:24] In our model, the chronic absenteeism rate is used, the chronic absenteeism rate that is used is the percentage of students in a school are chronically absent so that's the the metric that's taken for schools each of those nine indicators as you are all aware receive a performance level the performance level descriptions are a level one a two or a three a level one is when a performance uh an indicator

[01:46:59] meets or exceeds the state benchmark a level two is when the performance rate of an indicator is near the state benchmark and a level three is when that indicator rate is below standard and does not meet the criteria for level one or level two so when a school is accredited it looks at all of the performance levels of all of the indicators and that combination is what gives a school an accreditation status a school is accredited if all of the indicators receive a level one or a

[01:47:36] level 2 performance level and it's accredited with conditions when one or more of the indicators is a level 3 a school is accreditation denied when the school fails to adopt or fully implement corrective actions to address level 3 school quality indicators I wanted to provide a little bit of data on the chronic absenteeism performance for schools over the past two years that we

[01:48:07] have actually run accreditation data so our our model went into effect in 2018-19 and uh again in 1920 so that those were the the first two years that we have run accreditation on our new model and you can see the number of um schools that were a level one two and three for each of those years as well as the percent of schools that were in each of those levels in order to earn a level one

[01:48:41] a school had to have a current or cumulative three-year rate that's less than or equal to 15 percent to be a level two it's would be greater than 15 but less than or equal to 25 and a level three is greater than 25 percent so just to put that into a little bit of perspective we do have long-term goals in the state on the federal side where we're trying to get down to

[01:49:14] 10 percent is our long-term goal in 24 25. so again when we're looking at this data from these two years we can see just in the um the one year's worth of data from the initial year that we were already showing improvement in the number of schools that were rated a level one so that brings us to this school year in 21 22 and at the last board meeting you did hear from concerns expressed

[01:49:51] from alan siebert from roanoke city public schools and region six i believe they left a letter regarding the use of chronic absenteeism in accreditation this year and in general school leaders have reported that absenteeism has been up this year due to several reasons first and is the quarantine guidelines that have been, were in place at the beginning of the year, especially where students who were exposed to COVID-19

[01:50:30] had to be quarantined or if they actually had the illness where they had to be isolated. And at the beginning of the school year and through January 22, those quarantine and isolation periods were up to 10 days.

[01:50:46] and they currently remain at five days in some situations so you can see that easily if a student hit one or two quarantine time frames they could have easily gone over the chronic absenteeism benchmark with their quarantine or isolation we've also heard anecdotally that a lot of students were being kept home because of symptoms that were very similar to covid and parents could not distinguish whether students had covid or not also older students who had younger siblings if

[01:51:25] that younger sibling was sick the older students were staying home with the younger siblings so on various reasons related to covet 19 that students just have not been in school under normal circumstances we do believe that school divisions have control over the programs and the policies and the processes and practices they put in place to engage students in school and that is actually one of the reasons why it is one of the indicators because we believe that it is something

[01:52:04] that schools should be able to control um is the uh the student engagement however uh due to the absences due to covet 19 those absences were not necessarily a result of the lack of school level policies or practices that were put in place so the chronic absenteeism data for 21 22 may not actually reflect a school's efforts to engage students. I did want to bring your attention

[01:52:41] to a superintendent's memo that did go out. This went out in August of 21, and this memo was written to school divisions in anticipation of the students having to go out on quarantine.

[01:53:00] and so basically this memo stated that if students were to go out on quarantine or they were isolated but they were felt well enough or that they were not ill that school divisions were expected to provide remote instructions for students and that that that was just the expectation that that school divisions would find ways to engage students in learning while they were home

[01:53:33] so while these guidelines were communicated in august of 2021 they may not have been implemented with fidelity across the state and there was several reasons why this may not have occurred there has been staffing shortages in schools which includes teachers who were out themselves on quarantine or for illness, as well as a shortage of substitute teachers. There may have been just the sheer number of students who were being quarantined at one time and the school's

[01:54:11] ability to manage the virtual learning. There is also in some areas in Virginia, especially in the rural areas, a lack of reliable internet connectivity. And also that last bullet talks about a lack of understanding of the flexibilities afforded to schools. And I have received inquiries well into the school year from school divisions who were not aware that this guidance was

[01:54:42] even out in August. So if they were contacting me well into the school year, they were probably not tracking attendance like they should have been a track of tracking it in addition the student records that schools have been keeping may not accurately represent the status of students who are actually absent or receiving remote instruction there are some schools who put in

[01:55:16] codes into place to track when students were out on quarantine some schools didn't did not do that there were some schools who probably marked that information for all students in a particular class that may have been quarantined and may not if for instance say it was a rural area and that class got paper packets or something to work on they were marking those students present regardless of whether there was interaction during the day so that's just another

[01:55:52] example of something that could have happened so again these student records may or may not accurately reflect actual attendance information and because of all of these different circumstances that have a surrounded chronic absenteeism the department is asking the board to consider flexibility surrounding the use of this indicator and the determination of accreditation for schools

[01:56:23] in 22 23 and there is um under the standards of accreditation there is um authority granted to the board to adopt special provisions related to the use of school quality indicators so it is under your authority to adopt these special provisions and what we are actually asking you to consider is the adoption of special provisions to remove the chronic absenteeism

[01:57:00] indicator from the determination of school accreditation status for 22 23 only in doing so the earned performance level and the chronic absenteeism rate will still be assigned to the school according to the so soa and it will still be reported for schools the data will be available to school divisions as they prepare for the 22-23 school year it will be available publicly to ensure

[01:57:36] transparency to all stakeholders in the community and part of that messaging that would go out to school divisions is to make sure that they realize that chronic absenteeism will remain a valued metric for school quality and it will be used in determination of accreditation status when we resume with the next accreditation cycle using the 22-23 school year data this particular screen

[01:58:14] does show just a couple of screenshots of some of the information that is reported out on that top part of this screen is a snippet from the accreditation detail report that shows the the percentage that rate that a school earned as well as its assigned level and that bottom screenshot is from a school quality profile that is on the videoe website that shows the

[01:58:48] level of the chronic absenteeism for a particular school again none of that is going to change it's just a matter of us not using this particular indicator in determining the accreditation status i do also

want to mention that the percentage for each of the schools is also in the school quality indicator um i i do not have a screenshot of it here but it is um on that those report cards

[01:59:22] as well so at the meeting tomorrow you will be requested to waive first review and adopt special provisions that will remove the use of chronic absenteeism from the determination of school accreditation status in 22 23 and the reason for the waving of the first review is that the board does not meet in may and preliminary accreditation information typically begins to report in july

[01:59:57] so it's being requested that the board take action on on this item at tomorrow's meeting so that school divisions can be provided advanced notification of the change and that our department of education data services staff has time to make the necessary changes to the programs and the reports surrounding accreditation so with that i will take any questions that you may have questions from board members thank you so much for that miss ipka

[02:00:37] Ms. Houlton. I was going to say thank you. That was very clear. And I think it's an important step that we do need to take for a temporary measure because of all the reasons. I don't have any questions. I just want to thank you for the very clear presentation. Thank you. I have a question.

[02:00:55] One short question is, you gave us data for 1819 and 1920. I thought it was interesting that 1920 showed some improvement because that did include the beginning of the pandemic. And then we didn't see 2021 data shouldn't we have that by now um for accreditation we did not run accreditation in 20. but but we ran the indicators the indicators um shouldn't we know how many schools we were level three for chronic absenteeism in 2020 we did not we didn't even run them okay okay

[02:01:29] so are we going to run them for 21 22 even though we're not going to if we adopt this proposal yeah we're going to run them for 2020 so there will be a one-year gap in the data but only a one-year gap right yeah we are we are running everything normal reporting everything out normal the only difference would be um that that indicator would be removed from the determination of accreditation status so i got you but there will still be i mean permanently you know going

[02:02:05] forward, there will be the one-year gap, 2021, then we'll resume gathering, analyzing, and publishing the data for 2021-2022, but we won't use it to determine accreditation status in 2022-2023. So then my question is, and maybe that we haven't gotten to this yet, for accreditation status for 2023-2024, one of the measures will be comparing chronic absenteeism in 2021-20, no, I'm sorry, in 2022-2023, normally we would compare it to the prior year? Is that what we would do? Compare it to 21-22? Because I'm a little

[02:02:44] bit worried if, okay, if this year is going to be a disaster and then we use it as the baseline, well, then everybody's going to be great because they're going to improve from the baseline. So this year, when they're doing the calculations, the year they're going to compare to is that 19-20 because that's that previous year. That was the last year that we actually calculated accreditation data so then you are correct in the following year um we would be using the data from this year and then the following year's data and so i just wonder whether we

[02:03:22] should look at and i don't think we have to do this for the purposes of the decision we're doing making tomorrow but do we want to look at if if the 21 22 data is that invalid and that extraordinary is it a decent baseline or should we go back to the 1920 baseline yes that's a very because you know if if if the bar

falls that low then everybody will be right above average improvement right even and the whole purpose we're not looking to make more schools be

[02:03:59] under the microscope but the purpose is to identify through the accredited accreditation with conditions labeled to identify the schools that most need our more intensive support and scrutiny correct um you know so if everybody and i guess you don't you can be level three based on sheer high percentage of chronic absenteeism even if you've shown improvement but for that improvement factor we will we'll take a look at it that's a very good point superintendent bailo thank you and i might just kind of put an exclamation mark on um on the

[02:04:38] response uh and the great question uh i i think it's it's really important to first of all call out this year as being super wonky not just because um of of circumstances with kids being in school but what it meant to be quarantined in september meant something different in november meant something different in february and mean something different now and i think that having sort of that moving target of um of who can or should or can't or won't be in school has just

[02:05:12] been really unfortunate and will invalidate the data that said you know we want to be really clear and intentional about making sure that absenteeism and chronic absenteeism still shows up on the school divisions report and on the data that they need to that our school divisions need to explain to their stakeholders um the onus is really on on them to tell that story that community story of look um we we have this because and that may look really different from community to community but the onus is to say we're not being penalized for this because it was a moving target but here's

[02:05:52] the narrative that needs to go with this color or with this this data that we're reporting other questions all right hearing none i think dr dr man i would i would just like to say thank you miss bethka for her presentation and thank you on behalf of all the economically disadvantaged

[02:06:24] schools and which we are trying our very best to get children back into the classroom yes dr so i'm kind of thinking through my question um so looking at the guidance that was sent out that that in some cases weren't wasn't widely uh people weren't widely aware of but you know we're having this conversation in tandem about virtual learning and and putting some guidance and guidelines or regulations around that and uh even as this the guidance reads you know schools

[02:07:01] uh should be offering meaningful opportunities and should be prepared to support students otherwise you know um they're quarantined and the opportunities weren't provided they should be counted as absent absent so i guess my question is do we feel like or do we know yet that even with this exception that we're you know all indicators right now is that you know we're we're on the we're on the up and up on this whole pandemic thing and nobody can predict where we'll go but even if if we stay the status quo just there's lingering effects still of what we're dealing with people

[02:07:38] still don't know if i kept my kid home monday because he had a fever when he woke up and by noon he was fine you know there's just this lingering effect um whereas um you know six months ago i would have ran off to get him tested by 9 a.m monday so it's just i'm just curious have we put any thought into um uh the potential if this is going to be enough you know um i know it's probably a little premature to answer that question but um again balancing that with where we're trying to go with raising some expectations and standards with supports for virtual learning

[02:08:12] to kind of help offset the ambiguity of what we face in the future it's just uh and i don't know if there's a question there as much as me thinking out loud um for the for us to keep in mind as a board i do and but i i do think that um as superintendent balo said it is going to require a lot of work on the part of the school divisions to kind of create their own story and determine what it is that caused all of these absences and kind of put a plan in place to address the individual situations that have occurred.

[02:08:48] I just know from the people that I have spoken to that they just said this year was just so taxing and just crazy with the amount of kids just rotating. So, hopefully that, you never know though, right?

[02:09:08] - Thank you, yeah. - All right, well, if there are no other comments, thank you so much. - Thank you. - Certainly a very clear presentation and forward to seeing you tomorrow. - Okay.

[02:09:26] - Next up, we're going to be joined by Ms. Jenna Conway. Very glad to have her here this afternoon to bring us current on the progress that was experienced with practice year one and talk a little bit about the guidance associated with practice year two and all things that are happening on the early childhood front in BDOE.

[02:09:52] So welcome, Jenna. - Thank you, good afternoon. I'm also joined today by Chris Myers from our team who is my lifeline if I receive questions that I'm unprepared to answer. But really pleased to be here this afternoon.

[02:10:09] Tomorrow we will bring an item related to a set of updates on the guidelines for practice year two. And what we thought would be wise is to take a step back today as part of the work session, revisit our bigger picture why, why we care so much about school readiness, how we've thought over the course of the last few years and work together to build a statewide measurement and improvement system, what elements we focus on most it comes to quality and then really excited to share some hot off the presses data with you about

[02:10:46] what we've learned so far in practice year one that should then tee you up nicely to be able to make a decision on the key set of changes that we'll be bringing tomorrow so first of all and i know we've talked about this in in various pieces we we talked a little bit about it we talked about early literacy the last time we came together but just to bring us back to our big picture why we fundamentally believe that every child in the commonwealth should have the opportunity to come to school ready and we know right now that that's not true for all all kids in virginia we know that this is a combination of tackling access and choice

[02:11:26] issues right making sure that all families have an affordable option that meets their needs and their children's needs and we also know it's a quality issue right making sure that all families can choose a quality option that will put their children on on track for success and this guides all of our work together today we will focus more on quality um but you know we sort of we know at the same time we have to make sure that there are sufficient resources in the system to not only help each educator and each program perform to its at a top level but to make sure that there's not enough overall options across the commonwealth um and as you'll hear throughout

[02:12:05] today and what we think is really important is gathering the the data every step of the way as we build this system to make sure that it works for virginia educators virginia families and virginia kids so with that in mind here's some of the important data from last fall in terms of all of the kids coming into virginia public schools we know that four out of ten kids came in ready and at least not ready in at least

one of these areas so our overall 58 percent of kids were fully ready, 42% were not ready in at least one area. You'll see our sort of biggest areas of concern

[02:12:41] right now are literacy and early math. What this means in terms of numbers is that 21,000 of the roughly 90,000 children that came into kindergarten this year are at serious risk of not being prepared to read by third grade unless there's intervention. When we look more in sort of go in depth and look at this data we also see that there's some really persistent disparities in which kids do and do not have opportunity to come to school ready so we look at again if if overall 42 percent of kids are not ready so that's kind of the state the statewide baseline you see

[02:13:18] that those gaps go up for our black and hispanic students you see that our students from low income backgrounds are less likely to have the opportunity to come to school ready our english language and multilingual learners and our children with disabilities we know that preschool works the statistic that i often cite is that when we look at the kids who look least ready some of our low income children whose parents report no preschool experience whatsoever two-thirds of them are coming in not ready right in sharp contrast are kids who have the opportunity whether it's in a

[02:13:53] child care setting virginia preschool initiative mixed delivery or head start parents who report preschool experiences those kids come in much more likely to be ready than those whose parents report no preschool experience so we know what works the challenge is really scaling enough quality options statewide so before we jump into kind of well let's get talk specifically about the details of quality we thought it was really useful last month when we talked about literacy and we got a little bit more in the weeds and sort of the the nuts and bolts of this we wanted to talk

[02:14:29] about why does school readiness really matter why is there such a connection between a kid's ability to identify first letter sounds and persist at a task and do basic counting at the beginning of kindergarten until their third grade reading right into their eighth grade results their high school graduation rates a lot of that has to do with what's actually happening with kids birth to five So this should be the easiest graph of the afternoon and data point, right?

[02:14:58] But 90% of children's brain development happens before the age of five. And part of the reason we talk about literacy and math as well as social skills and self-regulation is those foundational interpersonal skills are built at the same time that we're laying the foundation for the academic skills, right?

[02:15:17] And I know that we've worked very closely with Dr. Mann and this board as we developed our early learning development standards and we said they can't just be about letters and numbers, right? Because so much of this brain development is in the context of relationships and kids are building this sort of social emotional skills that it takes to be successful. Another way to look at it, and I think this is a really helpful graphic, is to see how these things are connected. So even though they're not talking back to us, and we appreciate that, although their cries can pierce their eardrums.

[02:15:49] Children are learning vocabulary at the earliest stages. And we're using technology, things like MRIs, to analyze their brains. We're using devices that capture the language back and forth between parents and caregivers and young children. And we see gaps in vocabulary development in terms of what kids know, even if they can't say the word, but what they can identify in terms of objects as early as 18 months.

[02:16:15] we can predict, you know, based on vocabulary, attention, and general knowledge when you're three and four, where it'll be by third or fourth grade, right? So what we previously thought is kids playing or it's just baby talk. It turns out that these are actually critical foundational skills.

[02:16:34] And you'll notice again here, this isn't just first letter sounds or rhyming, right? Kids are actually developing core content knowledge. They're developing vocabulary, oral vocabulary, right they're not writing it or reading it but then we teach them to decode as some of our literacy experts talked about last month it then unlocks that incredible set of words that they know and kind of affiliated with objects and with context and then we know that third grade reading ability is one of the best predictors of high school graduation so really it's incredibly important to think about this not only as well this is a nice to do thing for kids and for working

[02:17:11] families but it's essential if we want to have third grade and graduation results this gives you the the numbers in virginia in particular and so this is a little bit of a more complicated graphic but basically this takes the pal score in the fall of kindergarten this is where he breaks into five buckets right so the green column is those kids who do the best the red columns is those kids who who who struggle the most and what you see is there's a direct connection from where you are when you enter kindergarten and how you do in third grade. So in other words, if you do very well when you come in on PALS in that fall kindergarten, 90 percent of you are going to be

[02:17:49] reading by third grade, right? No matter what experience you have. This is across the board, regardless of which elementary school you are in in Virginia. In sharp contrast, if you come in and you score in that lowest quintile, fewer than half of them are going to be able to caught up no matter how good our schools are by third grade, right? And so really recognizing that that we have to address this birth to five context if we want to have everybody have that opportunity to come to third grade reading.

[02:18:18] Not that, I don't think all of the work that we're doing on early literacy matters, right? Absolutely, we want, particularly when you look at that middle, right? That is the difference maker, right? The difference maker between who is and who is not, particularly in the middle, are those strong K-3 experiences.

[02:18:34] But I just, I show us that 45% just to show it how hard it is to catch up in early elementary if they don't have the early childhood experiences that put them on track for success so we talked a little bit about this right both the access and the quality piece again i'm not going to spend a lot of time talking about access today but really focus more on quality how do we give kids the experiences that put them on track for success and this is another really important graphic on sort of why make the investment in quality you could address your workforce issues if you just said hey i just want to make sure that kids

[02:19:11] have a healthy and safe place to go right we just want to make sure that mom or dad or guardian can go to work but you won't get the same returns unless you really address the quality unless we are intentionally supporting the learning and development of kids and a national economist dr james heckman has run this data across the board and what he basically says and i always say this carefully particularly when i'm in a k-12 organization is basically you get the best return on investment in those early years not that remediation isn't important but in terms of public dollars where you get for the most bang for your buck is in those early childhood years

[02:19:47] because of the way in which the human brain develops and how much of that foundational learning occurs there but he has since gone on to say that just sort of preschool alone or just child care

alone is not sufficient that you get you know if you look at 13 percent return on investment versus seven to ten percent is by making sure that we have settings that and educators that intentionally support the learning and development of children so when we talk about how do we make sure every kid has the opportunity to come to school ready it's about making sure we have sufficient choices for families to choose from but also that families can be assured no

[02:20:25] matter what choice they're making with public dollars that it meets a certain level of quality and this is also what dr. Heckman said about kind of the importance of it I'm just going to highlight this last point which is that basically investing in high quality child care pays for itself in the first five years so really if we can figure out how to build a system where we can demonstrate that across our 9,000 classrooms that they are sufficient quality to put kids on track for success that the significant investment that Virginia is making is working for Virginia kids and families then we would have a return on investment in a much shorter

[02:21:02] time period than many of the other problems that we're seeking to tackle so let's talk a little bit about what we're doing here in Virginia just as a refresher for folks so we we this is some of the data and the information we shared with you last year when we were talking about kind of the initial set of guidelines we've been in a multi-year process to get to this point and we are at the point in this process where it's really in your hands right we have the state law that puts you in charge of this unified early birth to five early childhood system and calls on the board

[02:21:38] to set forth and establish a statewide uniform measurement and improvement system last year was our first practice year and this next coming year is our sort of practice year too so we're kind of learning as we're going. The big challenge in front of you and Dr. Heckman the economist often sort of speaks about this when he when he goes out there it's not enough we know how to achieve with one-off programs how to get to quality right and I would say you know Dr. Mann has done this throughout her career in terms of really going into programs and helping make sure that every aspect of those programs is excellent. The challenge is doing this at scale and you've probably read

[02:22:15] the headlines about some of the concerns that have come from Tennessee and other places right some of the head start fade out stuff like there really is the challenge is how do you do this at scale in a diverse context such as a state right we've got urban and rural and suburban you've got an incredibly diverse array of parent needs and community options and so we're trying to build a system that will do that at scale across every community in our in our state we've got to think about how we define quality in the way it's connected to child outcomes but also makes sense to our educators, right? We've got a very different workforce with early childhood than we do with K-12

[02:22:53] and is within your locus of control, right? Sort of how do we make sure that whether you're a family childcare in Alexandria or you're a school division in Southwest, right, that you understand what is being expected of you and you're supported to achieve. We've got to track improvement across the board and focus on growth and then we've got to make sure similar to what we've done in K-12 but in a different context that we're targeting those programs that have the greatest need we spent years and chris has led much of this work talking with the field about what are all the ways in which you can measure quality we were fortunate to receive that outside federal

[02:23:31] grant which allowed us to pilot with a diverse set of communities right so this wasn't just devised in a boardroom here in richmond but was actually built out in the field alongside practitioners

and we've landed on two really important measures that we think are so important that we want to look at them measure them and support improvement in every one of our 9 000 publicly funded classrooms those are interactions right using a nationally regarded measure it's called the class which is the classroom assessment scoring system there's an infant a toddler a preschool and kind of you can use a mixed age version that really looks at age and developmentally appropriate

[02:24:10] behaviors in the classroom and how our educators support that day in day out in curriculum making sure that all of our programs are using one of our approved curriculum and there are multiple choices and we'll talk about that in a second but those two elements we think are so important that we are asking you to set forth a system that will measure them across 9 000 classrooms and support improvement across that same scale why interactions so basically little kids and it's this is a perfect follow-up really to virtual virginia right for anybody who had a child under the age of four during this pandemic is little kids don't learn from screens now they like screens right and they

[02:24:47] will they're probably better on screens than the rest of us but little kids infants toddlers preschoolers learn in the context of relationships with trusting adults right going back to that example i shared earlier right about kind of vocabulary 18 months they've even done studies right and you do three sort of scenarios you've got an infant learning from an actual adult an infant just watching a video and then an infant on facetime and the infant that learns the vocabulary best is the infant learning from the actual adults right not from the tv show as much as i love sesame street and not even from facetime but it is the full oops sorry it's the

[02:25:27] full context of being there connecting following the infant's cues being able to touch the infant right support the infant that is how children learn and so we've got to figure out using kind of the science that we know about child development how do we support the highest of quality interactions across all of these classrooms right and it's also very dynamic right miss tammy knows better than anyone right what a three-year-old might want at 9 10 a.m looks very different whatever a three-year-old is at at 9 11 a.m right in terms of the moods and all that's bringing in so really figuring out how do we support learning development in a way that's real

[02:26:04] for infant toddler and preschool learning we also know and i think this is really important and i know we've talked a lot about this that this isn't just this is not about kind of having a bachelor's degree right and that we know that you don't need a bachelor's degree to provide quality interactions across these settings and that's really important as we step into this work with infants and toddlers and preschoolers we want the highest of quality of educators but we absolutely have to acknowledge where the field is at and that some of our most extraordinary educators might not have all those letters behind their name so we know from looking at the data the national data on

[02:26:43] class which is a measure of interactions that we can see high quality in state-funded preschool head start child care family day homes infant toddlers rural settings this isn't just limited and this really enables our workforce which is one of the most diverse and extraordinary workforces i would say in education to be successful without requiring them to go off and get a degree so we also know that curriculum is important and largely because even though we've got extraordinary educators and we can call for the types of activities we want days with young children can be very very long as i can attest having spent monday with my four-year-old

[02:27:20] um and so really thinking through how do we support all of our educators to use curriculum this is very common already in k-12 right you're very hard-pressed to go out and see a classroom that's not using curriculum but as i'll share in a moment that's not necessarily across the board in early childhood and so just taking a moment to recognize how important curriculum is in terms of making sure that there's clear goals for all kids right that you're what you're doing that day is intended to sit learning that there's activities that engage kids kids also need to be engaged in their own learning they are not going to sit still they're not going to do worksheets

[02:27:57] in fact of the opposite effect right where you see kids acting out is if they don't have the opportunity to engage and you want to make sure that there's kind of consistency across their classrooms as we look to expand and serve more three and four-year-olds we know that what four-year-olds needs probably looks slightly different from what three-year-olds needs right and so making sure that we're we're shaping those experiences based on their age um and we also know that curriculum can work and so when you look at the important measure of outcomes making sure that we're using curriculum that we're supporting educators to use curriculum it's not just enough to have the box on the shelf, right, but that they're supported to use it day in, day out is

[02:28:35] really important. One way I think about this in early childhood is sort of the, you know, does your child's early childhood program do crafts or does your child's early childhood program do art, right? And Tammy's smiling, she knows what I'm talking about. I will say with one of my littlest ones, first experiences, all the cutest crafts came home, right? Little pictures with her as a Bumblebee, something for Thanksgiving, whatever else. Then I realized, for as I went, my child moved on to another program, that that actually wasn't art. That was craft, mostly shaped by the adults. Children's art is scribbling, right? Children's art is, as my husband often observes

[02:29:11] from my four-year-old classroom, a lot of cutting of shapes that you're not exactly sure what they are, right? But that is actually children developing those fine art skills. Crafts is not really curriculum, right? And I think this is just a really, that's a sort of example of an evolution.

[02:29:27] Those early childhood educators using crafts, they come with the best of intentions. What we want to do is come in with a curriculum that says, you know, that's really cute, but what would really help this child explore their creative skills is allowing them to cut, allowing them to scribble, even if it doesn't look like a turkey or a bumblebee or whatever holiday we might be celebrating.

[02:29:48] so the summary here is sort of just a really kind of why we've chosen to focus on these two things again rooted on things we think can be used at scale that all of our educators can be successful at um and that are really closely tied to child outcomes you'll note that there's no reference of like directly testing kids and using that for stakes and i really want to make sure that's abundantly clear that is never ever what we would do here putting sort of high stakes standardized testing on two-year-olds is completely inappropriate doesn't work and probably will upset the two-year-old the teacher and the parents right so there are

[02:30:26] things like developmental screening that are used across the system right to help identify children who might need additional resources but we would never want to put high-stakes test testing on toddlers we also want to share kind of our vision on improvement I think this is really really important when you would kind of acknowledge and you hear and I know we've talked about as a board the different places that teachers start at you know and we know that some of our educators have been doing this for a

year have had tremendous resources right you know our kind of best in class we also know that some of our other educators are coming in getting $10 an hour and we're pulled off the street

[02:31:03] probably because ratios are so low and then we just needed somebody to be with these kids and so we want to acknowledge that we're building our system to kind of support all educators and what we've tried to do is be really intentional about a system that focuses as much on improvement as it does on performance so when we talk about what it will take and you'll hear me go into more detail here to observe and give 9 000 teachers and actually 9 000 classrooms right so it's close to 20 000 teachers feedback that's that's a big investment for virginia to make but there's no other way for those 20 000 teachers to improve

[02:31:40] their individual practice unless they receive that feedback, right? It may do, you know, Dr. Duran and Ms. Holton might be in sort of two teachers in two different classrooms, and we might get the best average for the site by just observing Dr. Duran, but it doesn't do Ms. Holton any good to get the feedback from what Dr. Duran is doing well and where he can grow. We need to get into every classroom every setting multiple times a year in order to give that feedback to individualize that support and to help that educator be a little bit better tomorrow than she is today and the same

[02:32:18] is for our leaders unless they fully understand what's happening in each classroom where the strengths are and the challenges are it's impossible to support their educators individually to achieve so vqb5 is what we call it you know again a focus on interactions and curriculum all publicly funded classrooms right so really kind of anywhere there's a public dollar making investment in early childhood we're getting into that classroom and then we're collecting the data that ultimately we can tie that to both short term the kindergarten readiness and long-term

[02:32:52] outcomes and that's really important so we look back and say okay how where are the places where we have bright spots in virginia how do we scale that and grow that we've got the data portal to do that we have just as a reminder we're kind of finishing up practice year one with about 1400 sites statewide and what we'll bring to you tomorrow is the guidelines for practice year two so still no stakes largely based on what we just heard today we knew that the pandemic would continue to have an effect this year and so we need a second practice year before this thing

[02:33:27] becomes real starting in the summer of 2023 and the first real ratings that will come out at the same time that accreditation comes out would be in the fall of 2024 any questions about why school readiness matters and kind of how we got to where we are today before i start to jump into the data on practice year one all right these are my favorite slides to do and i should note that chris has been engaging the field really broadly in this we talked with dr mann about this but we really think of this as a two-month socialization period so between now and when we ask your final

[02:34:05] approval in june to make sure we get this data to as many people as possible so we can make sure we're building the strongest possible system so we have started and really built since 2019 year by year growing the number of programs that are participating we've got 1400 sites participating this year and you'll see in the start we've got child care centers public schools and more than 250 family child care settings so a diverse array of programs and we nearly cut statewide coverage a little bit of work to do there in the east and we're working on that as we as we speak but when you think about the data that we're bringing to you to shape the decisions for year two knowing

[02:34:44] that the state is very well represented in this data we also know that many of our programs and our participants rather are satisfied with the experience and you might say well jenna you guys have a

state mandate like is satisfaction a part of that right like laws are laws to be followed this is like eating your vegetables like i don't ask my kids are you satisfied with the broccoli like eat the broccoli but what we've found from doing this work is that ultimately if you go back to that cycle of improvement if every educator and every leader in their system understands why this matters for kids you are going to get far better returns than if this is a statewide mandate

[02:35:21] right and so we spend a lot of time thinking about is this data system link p5 working for you is class working for you are you receiving feedback do you feel like this do you feel like this helps you to better work with kids because if we can if we can nail that quite frankly i think we can actually build a system that will lead to better results for kids because you have more satisfied educators and leaders so again across the board you see high levels of satisfaction about every aspect of our system and we heard this in quotes when we did a survey of several hundred folks across the state that they are positive about eating their vegetables or not exactly but

[02:35:59] you know what i mean um in terms of these are the things that are helpful to them um and really sort of shedding light on how do we get individualized supports to each of our of our programs we are making implementation progress i think this is important i think when you say you see that number We're like, Jen, you're going to observe 9,000 classrooms twice a year.

[02:36:26] How in the world are you building to that? We completed more than 4,200 observations this fall alone. All right, so we are growing and moving. That is probably twice what we did the fall before. And these are all being completed locally. We've had tremendous capacity, really making sure that there are various thousands of folks across the state trained in the infant tool, the toddler tool, and the preschool tool.

[02:36:50] and we have a third party as well going out so we'll talk a little bit more about this tomorrow in particular but making sure that all of those local observers the thousands of across the state that there's a good level of consistency so whether you're in the north south east or west and you're getting these observations that it's accurate consistent and supporting your growth and development we are observing all sides so that all types of classrooms so a lot of times you'll hear people talking about early childhood and it's all about three and four year olds. As you see, a significant portion of the classrooms we observed are infant and toddler classrooms. And we are doing all of this because we have dramatically

[02:37:27] grown the number of observers. So I should note, and Dr. Mann and Chris know this well, you can't just decide you want to go out and observe a classroom, right? As much as you might like to do that, and I'm not going to question anybody's capacity here, but in order to be a class observer, you have to complete a two-day training and take a really rigorous assessment.

[02:37:48] You have to score five, five 20-minute videos, and you have to be accurate to a certain degree in order to be certified. And that's really important. And I will note that I actually have done this, did this in my past, and did not pass the first time and was shocked. I was absolutely shocked I did not pass. But it was because I hadn't paid enough attention to the actual interaction so this is a really rigorous observation tool so when you look at all of the folks the thousands of folks we now have trained in that growth that means that all of those folks have gone through that training and that they have passed that test in turn it means when they go out

[02:38:27] and they observe educators they're not saying that 99 of our effective or whatever is happening on they are able to give precise feedback on strengths and opportunities for growth across more than 60

indicators it is a 90 minute observation roughly it's four 20 minute cycles for for toddler and for preschool so that's a really intensive observation this is not a walk through where i check things out i see what johnny and jane are doing this is again four 20 minute cycles and it takes quite a bit to kind of get this many folks passing the test but what it means one is you can get all these observations done and two that this is how many experts we have in

[02:39:04] adult child interactions now across the commonwealth and they will bring that lens to how they hire how they support staff how they think about professional development all aspects of the work we have also made some accomplishments in this in this uh practice year around using quality curriculum so we agreed with you all a year ago that we would provide points give you some points as part of the measurement for using a quality curriculum in at least one classroom we said that we didn't think it'd be appropriate to have one requirement kind of one statewide curriculum but that we would be willing to review curriculum whether those were standard kind of commercial

[02:39:43] products whether those were materials that have been developed locally to see if they met the national criteria for quality curriculum if they were aligned with our early learning development standard we have we have been working around the clock on this and we have 32 approved curriculum right now and really important in terms of making sure that there are options for all of our our programs i'll also i'm not going to give away my one of my most exciting data points yet but we have also launched stream in three which is an open educational resource and i'll explain why we did that but it's a low to no cost free option for curricula for programs that might not be able to

[02:40:21] develop their own or purchase one and so really important that you now know no matter where you go that there are a multitude of options for you if you want to choose to use one of the state's approved curriculum so here is the really important data on curriculum so we use link b5 to say of the 1400 sites participating in the system how many are using a curriculum and what you see is we look pretty darn good right two-thirds of programs are using one of those 30 plus approved curriculum about a third are not seems there's a challenge there we can work on that but wait not all things

[02:40:58] are sort of equally distributed this data shows that when you look at public schools right that 92 percent are already using approved curriculum that means nearly all of our public school classrooms and probably those other eight are in the process of getting reviewed are going to get the points for curriculum go about their merry way in sharp contrast right you'll see that only 55 of our child care centers are using approved curriculum 45 or not and less than half of family child care, right? And so what we said, like, wow, is that really a big lift? You know, to just use quality curriculum in one of your classrooms? Yes, it is, right? For child care and family

[02:41:36] child care, that is a big deal, right? And so this data is what led us to realizing that we would need to make a big investment, making sure that there was a free or no cost or low cost rather option for all of our programs, because telling each of these programs that they needed to go out and buy a two or three thousand or four thousand dollar curriculum for all their classrooms or saying somehow in your spare time develop a curriculum not an option right but it was this actual data coming from virginia that helped us shape the the the processes around the competitive

[02:42:11] process for stream in three once we'll talk we'll talk more more about tomorrow but that's just kind of really wanted to share that data i've shared with with superintendent balo and and even our governor this morning i think we're going to see this this chart really change over the next few years if we

do a really good job of helping people understand the why of curriculum we put affordable options with the right supports at their fingertips and we show them how it connects to improving their adult child interactions i bet you will see a very very different chart for the next few years we also learned this year and just note that this is continues to be such a big challenge

[02:42:50] maybe right up there with chronic absenteeism is just the teacher workforce shortages and so just wanted to kind of highlight another innovation that will be part of practice year two as well we've rec we've now called our teacher recognition program recognize b5 directly funding our educators who work in child care or in family child care family day homes with a direct incentive it's now up to two thousand dollars simply for staying so if your program is if you're publicly funded, you're participating in VQP5, your teachers work 30 hours more a week, then you receive up to $2,000. And really important to sustain this. As you'll see, we have grown this

[02:43:29] program. We had the data through the outside analysis with EVA that showed that it cut turnover in half. Just as a reminder, while we have 5% turnover in those K-12 classrooms, 92% of which are already using, or pre-K classrooms, 92% of which are already using curriculum, we have turnover rates pre-pandemic of 24% in child care, right? So not only do you need to make sure there's an affordable curriculum option, but you need to be prepared in a quarter of your classrooms to retrain your teachers, right? Because they're leaving at that rate. But what we found is we

[02:44:03] cut that turnover in half by simply paying teachers to stay, not for earning an additional degree, not for additional performance, but simply paying them to stay. And we've expanded program from 2 000 teachers to 2 700 teachers to over 6 000 teachers and 12 million dollars this year and knock on wood there's a pretty significant investment in this year's state and federal budget we'd like to see this be more money per teacher next year as well as our goal is roughly 10 000 educators in practice year two so really important investment that's directly tied to

[02:44:38] keeping that turnover down i think we'll see in the data from link b5 that until we can figure out how to address turnover it is going to be really hard to get sustainable quality improvement across child care and this is in the words of educators and just really touching i i won't read all the words on the slide because i'll probably start crying a little bit but just how important these resources are and you take this back to again how little kids learn and how much of that brain development counts and it is really hard for me to talk and engage with you if i have a health

[02:45:13] crisis at home that i can't figure out how to pay for right if i can't get to child care because i can't afford you know a vehicle that works right that i would like to stay and work in child care but when amazon is offering 20 bucks an hour like even though that's not my passion it becomes really really hard to do that and then for extraordinary leaders like dr mann when you're just like you know every three months every month rehiring you know it's really really hard to focus on on interactions and curriculum because you're just training on the basics yet again month after

[02:45:47] month so as we wrap up and uh just wanted to share you know one of the things that really important and one of the things i'm most pride of pride about proud about rather is our satisfaction with the field and that comes from extensive engagement so this just gives you a sense of sort of from all of the webinars that we're doing to kind of going on the field to the getting out there and having Chris share this data to working with the ready regions just we're constantly trying to say how can we do this better how

can we make this work for you and we will continue that we did that last year we'll do this this year and we'll continue that sort of throughout throughout this process

[02:46:24] again modeling right that we think we can be a little bit better tomorrow than we are today and what I will share with you tomorrow really will help address kind of as we as we sort of reflect back on what have we learned so far and what do we want to do differently for practice year too we'll begin to address some of the concerns that came up so overall i presented the really rosy picture today right what's working well what we want to sustain and the big picture for tomorrow is much of what we brought to you a year ago we want to keep we're not calling for any dramatic changes but we are hearing from the field that we need to be a little bit more clear on who needs to participate we need to make sure that there's clarity about who can observe and some

[02:47:02] of the specific information about those protocols we need to provide more information about the the curriculum options so it's been a work in progress in terms of getting to 30 approved options and finding a statewide option but we know that people want to know more and need real support I'll give as an example I think within the first 10 days of opening up the state the the free or low-cost option I think we had over a thousand classrooms want to sign up right there's a real demand there it's really figuring out how we respond to that demand talking about data entry how we support the field the importance of the staffing shortages educator

[02:47:39] stress and again as we continue to hear across the board right that the behaviors that our children are bringing a natural response to a global pandemic that is lasted for more than two years a lot of it is playing out in our family day homes in our child care settings and our head start and early head start settings and in our classrooms really thinking about how do we support our programs to deal with that as they're also helping to put kids on track for success.

[02:48:07] All right, with that, what questions do you have for me this afternoon and for Chris? Questions? Dr. Duran. Well, I'll just say wow, wow, wow. I remember when you first came to us and started presenting, and I'm just so excited to see the progress that you made, your commitment. You always inspire me just listening to you, first of all. But I think just hearing today, in particular, the advancement in the area of curriculum and providing that guidance well i did well you did note 92 percent of school divisions are using some form of curriculum i do think having a state recommended curriculum for those that needed that support is very

[02:48:46] critical and i'm very excited to hear about the stream in three we talked several times ago when you were here about my concern about some communities not having access and not having the ability to purchase that well other school divisions like myself we do have resources to do that but there are many that do not and if we want to have equity around all of our early childhood students in the commonwealth having access thank you thank you thank you thank you for getting that in place so i'm just really really just want to give you a lot of praise and thank you for the work that you've done and i'm excited to see the work moving forward uh the class observations i think are critical and i loved hearing the training that i wasn't aware of that detail of training i

[02:49:23] knew that class observations were taking place i know there was some level of training but to hear that you even didn't pass the first one tells me how rigorous it is and the fact that there's a a lot of attention to detail and that's the kind of feedback we need to give our educators not just coming in and you're doing a great job it's wonderful to see the positive interaction they really need that direct feedback

and they want it as you saw in the responses here so thank you thank you thank you my only question is what i'll often ask everyone i'm sure you're not surprised is tell me a little bit about the work that's being done to support our english learners absolutely you and i've talked about this for a long time and you all know by now i ask this question all the time because it's a passion of mine to understand how we're helping all those students so can you

[02:50:03] talk a little bit about what's happening in that area you didn't talk about it today but i know you've been focused on no absolutely absolutely so a couple of things i think we're really working and chris is working very closely with our partners at the virginia early childhood foundation and looking at as particularly as you get to a large number of these observations are they are we doing it in a way that's sort of equitable and consistent right and there are sort of different settings and really two issues that have come up and we have a small pilot going on um around inclusive classrooms right for our children with special needs and making sure that we are taking into full context their development and how they're learning and their kind of

[02:50:41] classroom context might look different right than than some of the classrooms of their of their typical peers and so we're doing that work right now um one of the things we really look at in in addition to passing that rigorous observation on class, finding folks who have special education experience to do those observations, right?

[02:51:00] Versus having somebody kind of come in who's not familiar, right? If you have nonverbal children, the interactions look different than if you have verbal children, right? Even if they happen to be the same birth age of three or four. I think similarly, we've been doing a lot of work. It's still a challenge, right?

[02:51:16] With some of the staffing challenges to make sure that we have observers can observe language uh classrooms with uh various languages right so i know we heard at our early childhood advisory committee meeting last month of of a situation in which we did have an observation right where the observer wasn't fluent in spanish and there were some interactions between the adults and children in spanish and that educator didn't probably get full credit right because the observer wasn't aware of what was going on and so when we we took that feedback we went and followed up and so really making sure that when we think about that I should almost add a line right that

[02:51:54] chart of the observers is making sure that we have the right number and in the right location of observers who have special education experience observers who are prepared to do work in other languages challenged in Northern Virginia with all of the many languages spoken and we're continuing to kind of work very closely with that ready region to to address that I think sort of similarly as we continue to grow out stream in three and other sort of look at other kind of bilingual resources how much of that is a fully bilingual curriculum i should go back and check on how many

[02:52:28] of our approved uh curricula are as well as what are the sort of supplements to support our educators who are working in different languages but we have great representation on the early child advisory committee and that was again you know something that came up last month and was really important right we know as we roll this out that not every observation experience will will will work and figuring out how we prevent that from happening will be really important thank you i appreciate that very much and i know you're very very focused on this i would just and i know this slide is here is stakeholder feedback but i would just encourage that you also somehow talk about

[02:53:05] this work yeah you specifically called out enhancements to practice your two guidelines i would love to see that also called out yeah in a very specific way to say how you're going to and and how we are going to help all, whether it's centers, whether it's at home, or whether it's public school divisions, really meet the needs of those students in a different way.

[02:53:23] Because it is unique. And I do think if you have staff that are not, that don't have degrees and trained in this area, then they're going to need that additional support to understand that. And sometimes that even has implications in the last bullet about challenging behaviors in the classroom where a student is not able to verbally communicate, either because it's not their primary language or maybe they have a disability in that area.

[02:53:43] That sometimes exhibits itself as behaviors that then are treated as punitive or consequences when it's really about a support that that child needs. So I know you're on it. I just wanted to make sure that I call that out in a different way and that we articulate that. No, no, I think that's important. And we can certainly think about that.

[02:53:59] I probably can't make changes for tomorrow, but I think as we think about what we need to do for June. But I think the other point too, and I really want to raise this, particularly when I think about family child care in your area of the state, is it's not only about some of the additional needs of the children classrooms but also what are the unique strengths right and so when i when i have met and gone and spent time in nova with some of our family child care providers what families want for their infant toddlers is a experience in which those educators are using children's home language right and and i think

[02:54:34] if you if you can't figure out whether it's via you know a video observation that then is translated, right, or getting a, you know, a bilingual observer, but those interactions that make children feel safe, right, the sort of, I think about, you know, particularly in sort of Spanish, some of the sort of the phrases, right, that kind of make a child feel comfortable, that is a necessary condition for a child to kind of pursue at a task, right, right, like it's not, you know, and if you miss out on those cues, on those ways in which those educators are making children feel safe, encouraging a particular behavior, asking a question,

[02:55:13] then you're actually not fully highlighting their strengths. And I think that's really important when we start to look at kind of how programs look side by side, that we're able to take that strengths-based approach, because I think that's what families want. And instinctively, I think that's really important that our system doesn't say, we're only going to measure you on what you do in English when, in reality, some of the children's most important learning might be happening in other languages.

[02:55:40] Thank you again very much. I'm really excited about your leadership. Thanks, Dr. Jones. Ms. Holton? Ms. Thank you. Again, I'll echo the wow, wow, wow. I'm especially impressed with the growth in BQ/B5 participation.

[02:55:58] Those numbers across different settings are really impressive. Thank you. quickly, I know we're getting towards the end of the day, but Virginia Literacy Act, what implications does that have for your work? How do we make sure this work aligns well with that work? Absolutely. I think it's really exciting. I mean, Superintendent Baila and I have had the opportunity to talk about it. I mean, again, I think kind of being able to tie these two things together, having spoken with Delegate Coyner, gosh, dating back to last fall and helping her understand the importance of really focusing on K3 in a way that would build on what we're

[02:56:37] doing, right, rather than trying to recreate it, I think really kind of played out in the session. You know, it was supported in a very bipartisan way in the same way that our work is and continues to be important. I think this focus on curriculum, right, and again, providing, making sure that it's approved by the state, right, while they're all choices for communities, I think is really important it also positions us really well to support the implementation of curriculum and i think you dr duran you probably know this better than anyone right but again the hardest work around curriculum is you know no matter what any expert or vendor tells you isn't the actual production of

[02:57:15] the curriculum right it's supporting each educator to use it with the variety of kids that they're they bring um they come into your classroom right each year and so um you know i think this focus on curriculum i think this focus on this data and on growth what we're investing in terms of the overhaul and pals will allow us to better look at growth right rather than just these point in times but really where are kids growing the most right and how do we learn from that and build on those on those practices so i think the timing is incredibly fortuitous um and i think we'll

[02:57:51] work really closely with our k-12 counterparts to think about you know both on the work on curriculum on the professional development and on the data infrastructure how do we make sure that there's strong linkages um i also think all of our work will uh help as we think about the feeder pattern to to schools realize and i know i've had this conversation with national audiences ever and ever like your feeder pattern to your elementary school is not just your vpi classroom right i mean it is this broader set and as we get this data and as our k-3 leaders and principals and central office

[02:58:31] staff are focusing on what's happening there also being able to put side by side some of the data what's happening across the array of their publicly funded programs at the community or region level i think is going to be just so important and really change the conversation i'm hopeful that we'll start to see more cross-pollination in terms of professional development between school divisions and partners right that that school divisions will recognize like if i don't get my kindergartners coming in with the right level of early literacy skills like that makes my work that much harder and really again not trying to run it all directly but to think

[02:59:09] differently about their partnerships with child care family day homes head start in their communities i all think this focus on k3 and this data will tee us up nicely to support that type of coordination and collaboration and delegate corner did not pay me to say that other question tomorrow excellent thank you all so much i'll see you tomorrow excellent we have one more presentation and i know

[02:59:48] Shelly, you were pulling up the rear last time, I believe, with our final presentation. I'd like to be your closer. Yes, you are our closer for the work session. So welcome. And you're going to be talking about the alternative assessment program that we need to attend to.

[03:00:09] Thank you very much. And Sam Hollins is also in the audience because this really is a collaborative effort between our two units. Before I begin the presentation, I wanted to give a little bit of background about why we're even talking about this today so you all are well familiar with the standards of learning assessments that the majority of our students take including most students with disabilities but we do have a small number of students with significant cognitive disabilities who are not able to access the content contained in the standards of learning or in the standards of learning assessments those students really are learning a modified curriculum

[03:00:48] and they participate in an alternate assessment and the name of that assessment program is the Virginia alternate assessment program in Virginia better known as VAP we do have a new testing program in place this year a new alternate assessment and because of that you will have to set new cut scores on that that will occur in June but because you all do not meet in May i will be sending you out information about the the preparation for the cut score development in may so i wanted to make sure that um you all had some background both on the bap and also on the

[03:01:25] standard setting process before you get that information so a little bit of background um we've had an alternate assessment program in virginia for a very long time the first one was developed in 2000 2001 and that assessment was a portfolio based assessment so teachers selected what was called an aligned standard of learning at that time and collected evidence that the student had mastered that content and put it in a portfolio over the years that changed slightly but it always remained a portfolio all states have to go through a peer

[03:02:05] review process with the united states department of education and in february of 2019 we were informed that the portfolio-based VAP was no longer permissible under the Every Student Succeeds Act, and that Virginia was directed to immediately develop a new assessment program.

[03:02:25] And we needed to have that in place by this year, 21-22. So, what did we do? We convened an internal group, as I said, really contained staff from both the Student Assessment Office and also the Special Education Office. We looked across the country. The National Center for Educational Outcomes is a federal center that deals with students with disabilities. We also taught to USED and we began to develop a work plan. We looked at alternate assessments all across the

[03:03:00] country to try to find one that we either could adopt or a state we could partner with. And And eventually we selected the Behavior Research and Testing Unit at the University of Oregon and they actually developed the alternate assessment that's used with the Oregon Department of Education.

[03:03:19] So ultimately our partners are the University of Oregon and the Oregon Department of Education. So of course we had to have content to base the assessment on. So what we have is the Virginia Essentialized Standards of Learning, better known as the VSAWs.

[03:03:35] And so, in 2020, BRT and VDOE personnel worked with Virginia Special Educators to use the essentialization process, and it was developed by BRT, and really it takes the SOL content and essentializes it so that these students can access it, and it really reduces the content and depth, breadth, and complexity.

[03:03:59] I should have brought my water with it. Get yourself. Thank you. So that it would be appropriate for these students to access. so here's okay thank you so much all right i have lots of water now all right thank you all right so um i we have lots of examples but i wanted to provide just one for you so if the standard of learning is the student will estimate and determine the summer difference of two whole numbers the essentialized standard would be added subtract whole numbers up to 20. so same content but really

[03:04:31] reduced and in complexity and i'm going to talk a little bit about what the test itself looks like just so you all will have a sense of what it is before you look at the cut scores um so it is available to eligible students they do have to meet an extensive set of criteria but essentially students with significant cognitive disabilities grades three through eight in high school and it is in the area of reading mathematics and

science test items of course they're based on the v sols and they are multiple choice they will include three answer options items are presented in an

[03:05:10] online format but each student can also have a paper version so we're administering the test now and students can look at the test online and use the accessibility features that are available like text to speech or the color contrast but then each student also has the ability to have a paper to copy so we're trying to be as flexible as possible because these students do access content in different ways the test items are read to the student either through the examiner the test

[03:05:43] examiner or through the text to speech option if they're using the online version so in addition to either being presented online or in paper we also have lots of flexibility about how the student responds they can select the answers themselves either online or using paper they many of these students use assistive technology they can access it in that way and then the the teacher or the

[03:06:17] examiner um may enter the students responses in the online system um and and they provide their answers in their preferred modality so they might state their answer they might point to it some of of these students use head movement or eye gaze to indicate their their choice and so in all of those ways the student is indicating their choice and then the the teacher or someone at the school will enter their answer into the online system so remember this was our v-sol so now I'm going to show you what an item

[03:06:53] looks like so this would be a VAP item very simple six plus eight equals and then the answer choices are in boxes and then the student could point to the answer or perhaps use assistive technology so now that was an overview of the test a very brief overview and now i'm going just to remind you about the standard setting process many of you have been through the standard setting process before um i know dr durand it's a very exciting process but we'll review the steps one more time so um because they are being administered the first

[03:07:30] time this spring you do have to adopt new cut scores and just a reminder cut scores are the minimum number of correct answers a student has to get to be in the level of proficient or advanced and as we always do we base the recommendations that come to you on committees of educators so this time around we are convening educators twice and i'll explain a little bit more about why that is in a few minutes we met with committees last week and then we'll meet with them again on a saturday in may because you do not meet in may we will be bringing this before you in june and

[03:08:10] asking you to waive first review and adopting the cut scores and that's really so parents can receive their students test results we also need the results for accreditation and also for federal accountability um because we will not be bringing the item to you formally until june we do want to provide you with information in may so that you will have time to look at it prior to the june board meeting and then emily will also help us to post it publicly so even though there will not be

[03:08:45] two reviews of the cut scores you and the public will have about a month to to look at the data before we ask you to act just a reminder standard setting is a systemic way of making judgments and we really base uh our recommendations primarily on teachers and then we will also talk a bit about the impact data that a different group of teachers will look at in a few minutes so for that we have three performance levels we have does not meet proficiency which really is

[03:09:22] is fail proficient in the standards and then advanced detainment so we use a procedure called angoff it's the same one we've used since 1998 for the committees of educators we use this time it was

teachers who are familiar with the the v-salls and also have experience in teaching students with significant cognitive disabilities of course we always train our committee members when we do standard setting. And then the first thing they do is review what's called

[03:09:58] the performance level descriptors. And this is just a description of what is expected for a student to be proficient in the content for VAP. So here is one for grade three reading. And you can see that here, the student for reading, they would be able to identify the meaning of some words, answer some comprehension questions. If they're reading fiction, they might be able to identify some characters perhaps some settings so the next thing that happens is the committee members look at those performance level descriptors and then they think about so

[03:10:36] what would be the requirements for a student who is just over the border so a student who is just barely proficient what would that student look like and they spend a long time creating what's called borderline descriptors and what this does is it gives the committee members common understanding of the student who is just proficient or just advanced and they use that common understanding as they move into the next activity which is to review the test items so each committee member

[03:11:13] independently reviews the questions on the vap assessment and they thinking about students who are just barely proficient in that and they think about whether if they were had a hundred students who were just barely proficient in that would two-thirds of them get that item correct use the same activity for the advanced proficiency level and then when round one is completed round one really is just their first set of judgments so each committee member has recorded a yes

[03:11:48] or no for each item in terms of whether or not they think the student um would who is barely proficient would get that item correct and those yeses are added up and that becomes their cut score so if i had 10 items and i said that uh they're just barely a student professional student should get six of them correct then my cut score is six out of ten once we have round one then the committee members review the feedback from that round they get information about you know what

[03:12:24] the other committee members uh judged and then they have a lot of discussion about items where there is disagreement so i said that students should get a particular item correct and dr anderson said no then we would discuss that item and try to determine um why our why our judgments we're not consistent about that particular item so after round two um they again make the in round two they make the same judgments and again get feedback on the committee members other committee

[03:13:02] members recommendations and then round three is the last round here they're not reviewing individual items but instead they they can make adjustments if they want to to their cut scores i know all of you have been through standard setting before so that was just a quick review of of the process so um each test has its own standard setting committee so there's one for grade three reading one for grade four reading and so on and then vertical articulation is the last is the last committee that committee contains members of each of the standard setting committees

[03:13:42] and that committee's job is really to look across the recommended cut scores and determine if there's not consistency in the impact is there a content reason so the individual committees that look at the test items do not have access to the impact data the articulation committee is given estimated impact so if we adopt this particular cut score then this many students will fall into the proficient range and this many will fall into the advanced range the reason we have

[03:14:20] this particular committee look at the impact data is they do have knowledge of the content that's expected of the students so if there's not consistency in in the number of students who would be proficient the question they're asked is is there a content reason why that would typically we have articulation occur at the very end of the week that standard setting occurs but that we were not able to do that with that we do not have enough data in yet uh to have a reasonable estimate of

[03:14:53] impact so that's why we are having that separate committee meeting on a saturday in may for the teachers to review that impact data and so once we have that impact data we will prepare the charts that will come to you and actually what you will get will be the round three results from each committee and you'll get the articulation committee's recommendation and then lastly superintendent baylow will have an opportunity to look at the data and make any adjustments that

[03:15:28] she feels are necessary so we will give you that information um uh hopefully in mid-may and ask you to act on it in june so dr man uh be happy to answer any questions thank you one clarifying question so we'll be doing in june it'll be grades three through eight in high school as you said right will it be three through eight is it all of them in one or is it a third reading a third math and the third science or is that kind of looking at all at each grade i know high school would be different because they take great great question it is an individual test so

[03:16:03] it'll be three through eight an individual reading test for each grade level and then high school okay and then um same thing for math science is only given at five eight in high school to be consistent with where we administer the sol test thank you for the clarification other questions comments once again excellent job thank you so much for being here providing the overview and that wraps up our work session day so that means we can retire for the night

[03:16:43] thank you for your leadership today you did a great job sharing thank you dr man thank you phenomenal job thank you pam thanks so much for being with us we look forward to seeing you you tomorrow. Thank you guys. It's good to see you. We miss you Pam. I miss you all.

